The Archer and the Wind

How to Keep Going When Hard Work Isn't Enough

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The Archer and the Wind: How to Keep Going When Hard Work Isn't Enough

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The people in the illustrative stories in this book are composites. Their names are invented and any resemblance to real individuals is coincidental. The studies and historical events described are real, and their sources are listed in the Notes at the end of the book.

This book offers reflection, not professional advice. If disappointment has turned into despair, please speak to someone you trust or to a qualified professional.

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For everyone who did everything right
and still did not get what they wanted.

You were not foolish to try.

Nobody was ever promised the target.
We were given a bow, a breath and the wind,
and asked to try anyway.

Introduction: Four words I could not put down

Luck has a strange habit. It tends to show up just after you have prepared for it.

I have noticed this in my own life more times than I can count. When I work hard, my luck seems to work hard too. Perhaps you have felt it. You study properly for once, and the questions you practiced are the ones on the paper. You finally finish the piece of work you have been sweating over, and that same week the one person who could open a door happens to see it. You walk into a room ready, and the chance that appears is one you are able to take. It never happens on schedule and it never happens every time. But it happens often enough that you stop calling it coincidence. Somewhere deep down, you begin to believe that effort and good fortune are secretly on the same side.

And then you meet someone like Sara.

Sara is a composite, built from many people I have known and many more I have heard about, but you will recognize her. For two years she wanted one job. She read everything the company had published. She taught herself the software they used. She practiced her answers in front of the bathroom mirror until her younger brother banged on the door. On the morning of the

final interview, her mother prayed for her, and Sara prayed too, harder than she had prayed in years. The interview went well. She knew it went well.

Nine days later, a two-line email told her they had chosen someone else.

She read it standing in her kitchen. Within the hour, her mind had turned the company's decision into a verdict on her life. *You were never good enough. All that work was for nothing. There was no point in hoping, and no point in praying either.*

Sara is not unusual. She is everywhere.

A student studies for a full year for a medical entrance exam and misses the cut-off by two marks. A farmer does everything right, and the rain does not come. A man puts his savings into a small shop on a busy road, and six months later a new bypass takes the traffic somewhere else. A couple try for a child for five years. An athlete trains through every winter of her teens and tears a ligament in the week of the national trials. A family waits four years for a visa and is refused in a single paragraph. Someone loves another person with their whole heart and watches that person build a life with somebody else.

None of these people were lazy. Many of them prayed. All of them hoped.

* * *

So I was left holding two truths that refused to sit together.

The first: effort seems to attract luck.

The second: effort guarantees nothing.

Out of the gap between them came questions that followed me for years.

If our destiny is already written, and we will receive exactly what we were always going to receive, then why work so hard? Why pray? Why build hopes at all, if the ending is already on the page?

But if we receive what we work for, if effort really decides the outcome, then what is destiny for? Why do some people work themselves to the bone and get nothing, while others stroll into the very thing they barely wanted?

And if luck is the real master, if it is all a roll of the dice, why does it seem to favor the people who prepare?

There is a song by Linkin Park called “In the End” that a whole generation once shouted along to in bedrooms and cars. Its chorus is a confession that all the trying, all the distance covered, came to nothing in the end. I have noticed that people reach for that chorus at a very particular moment: the moment they stop believing in something they once believed in completely. It is the sound of a promise breaking.

This book is my attempt to answer those questions honestly, and to keep the promise from breaking you.

* * *

These are not abstract questions. People build entire lives on their answers, usually without noticing that they have chosen.

Some stand on the pillar of hard work. Discipline, early mornings, no excuses. They get a great deal done. They are also merciless with themselves when the results do not come, because in their system a bad result can only mean one thing: you did not work hard enough.

Some stand on the pillar of luck. They have seen enough unfairness to stop believing the neat story. They are often wise

about how much is out of our hands, and often tempted to stop reaching for anything at all.

Some stand on the pillar of destiny. What is meant for you will find you. This belief can bring deep peace. Held the wrong way, it can also become a beautiful excuse for not trying, or a waiting room where people sit for years in front of a door that has already closed.

And some stand on the pillar of hope. They lean toward the future with their whole hearts. They are often the bravest people in the room. They are also the ones who bleed the most when the answer is no.

Every one of these pillars holds up part of the truth. The trouble starts when we try to live on only one of them. Effort alone turns cruel when it fails. Luck alone turns passive. Destiny alone turns into waiting. Hope alone turns into fantasy.

The question is not which pillar is true. The question is how they stand together.

* * *

The answer I eventually found began with a very old picture.

More than two thousand years ago, a school of philosophers called the Stoics argued for centuries about fate, freedom and what a good life requires. The Roman statesman Cicero preserved one of their images in a book called *On Ends*, and it has stayed with me more than almost anything else I have read.

Think of an archer, they said. A good archer does everything in her power to hit the target. She trains for years. She chooses her bow and arrows with care. She reads the distance, sets her feet, steadies her breathing, draws and releases. All of that belongs to her.

But once the arrow leaves the string, it is no longer hers. A gust of wind can push it aside. The target can shift. The string may have been frayed in a place she could not see. The Stoics said that hitting the mark is something a good archer aims at with everything she has, and something she must not stake her worth on. Her aim is hers. The landing is not.

The first time I understood that image, something in my chest unclenched. The archer does not stop drawing the bow because of the wind. The wind does not stop blowing because the archer trained hard. Both are real. Both shape where the arrow lands. Neither cancels the other.

So this book is built around the archer and the forces that act on her arrow.

The bow is your effort: the training, the preparation, the work you do with your own hands. It is the one part of the story that is yours to shape.

The wind is luck: everything that pushes on your life that you did not choose and cannot control. Where you were born, the economy, the mood of the person reading your application, the stranger who happens to sit beside you on a train.

The written page is destiny. Perhaps you believe the arrow's path was known before you drew the bow. Perhaps you believe destiny is only the story we tell afterward, when we look back and see a path that seemed inevitable. Either way, the page is where the arrow lands, and the meaning we give to where it lands.

The breath is hope. Every archer knows the moment just before release, when you breathe in and hold still. It is the moment of hope before you take an action whose result you cannot know. For many people, that moment has a name, and the name is

prayer. For others, it is a silent *please*, or simply the decision to let go and see.

I will say more about hope than you might expect, because it is the force we talk about most loosely and need most deeply. Hope is not the pleasant feeling that things will work out. It is the reason the archer picks up the bow at all. Without it, there is no draw, no aim and no arrow. Some kinds of hope keep people alive through years of waiting. Other kinds break their hearts. Learning the difference may be the most important thing in this book.

And then there is *the archer*: you. The one who has to hold all four at once and still decide, every morning, whether to pick up the bow again.

* * *

Let me be plain about what this book will not do.

It will not promise you that hard work always wins. It does not, you already know it does not, and any book that says otherwise is selling you something. It will not tell you that every loss is secretly a gift. Some losses stay losses, and you can build a good life after them without pretending to be grateful.

It will not settle the great religious questions about destiny either. People of many faiths, and of none, will read these pages, and I want every one of them to find room here. I will not tell you what is written. I will show you why, whatever is written, your effort still counts.

Here is what it will do. It will give you a way to think about effort, luck, destiny and hope so they stop fighting inside you. It will show you what the research actually says about why luck seems to love the hardworking, why the best candidate often

loses, why the past always looks inevitable, and why some hope heals while some hope harms. It will give you words for disappointment, which is one of the loneliest experiences there is, partly because we have so few good words for it. And it will help you decide what to do next, when you have tried hard, hoped deeply and still lost: draw again at the same target, change the way you shoot, or turn and aim somewhere new.

You will meet a handful of people along the way: Sara, Daniel, Omar, Nadia, Maya, Adam and Lina. They are composites, invented names wrapped around real patterns, so that no real person's private pain is put on display. Everyone else, the scientists, the pilots, the prisoners, the philosophers, the farmer with the runaway horse, either really lived or comes from a story that people have been telling for centuries. You will find my sources in the Notes at the back.

At the end of each chapter there is a short section called *For your quiver*. An archer's quiver holds the arrows she will need later. Mine holds one line worth remembering and one small practice to try.

* * *

Before we begin, here is the whole book in five questions. I call it the archer's card. You can use it today, on whatever you are facing.

The bow. What is mine to do next?

The wind. What is not mine to control?

The page. What story am I telling myself about this?

The breath. What am I hoping for, and what action will I take without knowing how it ends?

The archer. Who am I, apart from this result?

Each part of the book goes deep into one of these questions. In Chapter 17 they become a full practice you can use for any goal, decision or disappointment. For now, just keep them close. Ask them the next time a result goes against you, before your mind starts writing its verdict.

I wrote this book for a particular person. Perhaps it is you. You worked hard for something. You wanted it in a way that kept you awake. Perhaps you prayed for it, and perhaps you still do. And something went the other way. Now you are standing in a field with an empty bow, looking at the place where your arrow should have landed, and wondering whether you were a fool to aim at all.

You were not. But I do not just want to tell you that. I want to show you, carefully and honestly, until you can see it for yourself.

Let's begin with a promise most of us believed long before we knew we believed it.

Part One: The bow

On hard work: what it can do, what it cannot, and the promise we thought it made

The bow is the only part of the story you hold in your own hands.

Chapter 1: The contract nobody signed

There is a moment that happens millions of times a day, all over the world.

A page loads. A list appears. An envelope is opened, a phone lights up, a name is read out. Results for an entrance exam. A scholarship shortlist. A visa decision. A job offer. A team selection. A biopsy. In that moment a person's whole body goes still, and their eyes move down the screen looking for one thing.

If it is there, the world makes sense. The early mornings were worth it. The sacrifices were worth it. The prayers were heard.

If it is not there, something breaks that is much bigger than the result. People do not just feel disappointed. They feel cheated, as though they kept their side of a bargain and the other side walked away.

I want to look closely at that feeling, because I think it holds the key to almost everything else in this book.

* * *

Most of us carry a contract we have never read.

It goes something like this. *If I work hard enough, and want it sincerely enough, and do things the right way, then I will get what*

I am working for. Many of us add a clause: *and if I pray, and if I am a good person, then the universe, or God, will make sure of it.*

Nobody hands us this contract to sign. We absorb it. We absorb it in school, where effort is rewarded with marks and stars and the teacher's smile. We absorb it from our parents, who tell us to work hard because they love us and because, in their own lives, it was the best advice they had. We absorb it from every film where the underdog trains, struggles and wins in the final scene. We absorb it from sermons and speeches that promise rewards to the diligent, often in a simpler form than the teachers behind them ever intended.

And it is not a bad contract to teach a child. It is mostly true, the way many useful things are mostly true. Children who work harder usually learn more. People who prepare usually perform better. Effort usually improves the odds.

The trouble is one small word: *will*. The contract says that if you do your part, the result *will* follow. Life never agreed to that clause. Life speaks the language of odds, not guarantees. And when we meet the gap between the two for the first time as adults, with something enormous at stake, we do not experience it as a lesson in probability. We experience it as betrayal.

* * *

Remember Sara in her kitchen, reading the email that ended two years of wanting? Within the hour her mind had written a verdict: *You were never good enough. All that work was for nothing.*

Now let me introduce you to the person who got the job. His name is Daniel, and he is a composite too.

Daniel also prepared for months. He also read the reports and practiced the answers and lay awake the night before. Daniel's

grandmother also prayed. On the morning of his interview, he was just as frightened as Sara.

Perhaps Daniel was a slightly better fit. Perhaps he had used the company's software in a previous job. Perhaps his last answer happened to touch a problem the manager was worried about that very week. Perhaps they went to the same university, and the manager felt a small, unnoticed warmth of recognition. Perhaps Daniel's interview was at ten in the morning and Sara's was at four in the afternoon, when everyone in the room was tired.

Sara will never know. That is one of the cruelest things about disappointment: it so rarely arrives with its reasons attached.

Here is what we do know. There was one job. Two people prepared seriously for it. Only one could have it. The result could tell the world who got the job. It could not tell the world which of them was worth more. It could not even say, with certainty, which of them was the better candidate. It could only say what happened.

Almost every contest in life has this shape. One scholarship, two hundred excellent applicants. One place in the final, eight athletes who have trained for a decade. One contract, five companies that would all do good work. One seat, many deserving people. When a hundred people deserve something and only one receives it, ninety-nine deserving people go home. If you are one of the ninety-nine, the contract tells you that you must not have deserved it. The arithmetic tells you something gentler and truer: there were simply more deserving people than there were places.

* * *

Why does the mind leap so quickly from *I didn't get it* to *I didn't deserve it*?

In the 1960s, a psychologist named Melvin Lerner began to notice something unsettling about how people respond to suffering. People often blamed victims for misfortunes they clearly had not caused. They would look at someone hurt by pure bad luck and decide, without quite admitting it, that the person must have done something to deserve it.

To test this, Lerner and his colleague Carolyn Simmons ran an experiment, published in 1966. Women watched what they believed was a fellow student receiving painful electric shocks as part of a learning task. (She was an actor; there were no real shocks.) When the observers could do nothing to stop it, many of them did something strange. They began to think less of her. They rated her as less attractive and less admirable than observers who learned that she would be compensated for her suffering.

Lerner's explanation became famous as the *just-world hypothesis*. Most of us need to believe that the world is basically fair, that people get what they deserve and deserve what they get. The belief is so precious that when we see undeserved suffering, we would rather rewrite the victim than give up the belief. Otherwise the world is a place where suffering can fall on anyone, at any time, for no reason at all, including on us. That thought is almost unbearable.

The research has been debated and refined for decades, as good research always is. But its central insight explains exactly what happened in Sara's kitchen.

When a result goes against us, the just-world belief does not disappear. It turns around and points at us.

If the world is fair, and I lost, then I must have deserved to lose. If I had really been good enough, I would have won. If I had prayed more sincerely, it would have been answered. So the failure is mine, entirely, and it says something about me, entirely.

That is not the voice of truth. It is the voice of the contract, refusing to admit it was never real.

* * *

There is a second way people respond when the contract breaks, and it is the mirror image of the first.

Instead of blaming themselves, they blame the whole idea of effort. *I did everything right and it didn't matter. So nothing matters. Hard work is a story they tell you to keep you running. Luck is everything. Or destiny is everything. Either way, I'm done trying.*

This feels like hard-won wisdom. It feels like you have finally seen through the trick.

But look closely and you will see the same contract in a different coat. Both responses assume that effort was supposed to guarantee the result. The first says: the guarantee is real, so I must have failed. The second says: the guarantee is fake, so effort is worthless. Neither considers the third possibility, which happens to be the true one.

Effort was never a guarantee. It was a contribution. It changes the odds. It does not sign a contract with the outcome.

* * *

The people who understand this best have always been farmers.

No farmer has ever believed that plowing guarantees rain. A farmer knows the whole list of things that can ruin a season: drought, flood, locusts, hail, blight, a collapse in prices at harvest.

Every one of them is outside the farmer's control. Some years the farmer does everything right and the crop fails anyway. Farmers in every culture have songs and prayers and proverbs about exactly this.

And every farmer plows.

They do not plow because plowing guarantees a harvest. They plow because not plowing guarantees there will not be one. Effort does not decide the outcome. It decides whether an outcome is possible at all. The rain may or may not come. But if it comes, it will fall on a prepared field or an empty one, and that part belongs to the farmer.

This is what the contract got wrong. It treated effort as a price, like money handed over at a shop counter in exchange for goods. Effort is more like planting. You put something real into the ground. You give it every chance you can. And then you wait under the same sky as everyone else.

* * *

I need to be careful here, because there is a cheap version of this idea that does more harm than good.

The cheap version says: *Don't be sad. You can't control outcomes, so just let it go.* That is not what I am saying. Sara is allowed to be sad. She is allowed to be angry. She wanted something good, she worked hard for it, and she did not get it. Grief is the right response to that. It would be strange if she felt nothing.

My point is narrower, and I think more useful. Sara's sadness is appropriate. Sara's verdict is not.

She is right to grieve the job. She is wrong to conclude that her preparation was worthless, that she is not good enough, that hope was foolish or that effort does not matter. Those conclu-

sions go far beyond what the evidence can carry. One email, from one company, about one position, cannot hold that much weight. It was never built to.

It helps to keep two words apart. *Deserve* is a moral word. It lives in the world of fairness, character and effort. *Receive* is a word about events. It lives in the world of odds, competition, timing and other people's decisions. Sara deserved respect for the way she prepared, and she deserves it still. She did not receive the job. Both are true at once, and the second does not cancel the first.

Hard work deserves respect even when it does not receive applause.

* * *

So what did Sara's effort actually do, if it did not get her the job?

I do not want to rush to consolation, because consolation offered too quickly sounds like dismissal. But it is worth looking honestly at the ledger.

Her effort carried her into the final round, out of what was probably a very large pile of applications. It moved her odds from tiny to real. It taught her the software, which she now owns and will carry to the next application. It taught her to talk about her failures with honesty, which is rarer than it sounds. It introduced her to two people in the industry who now know her name. And it showed her something about herself she had not known: when she wants something, she can pursue it with discipline and nerve.

None of this is the job. If you had offered Sara all of it in exchange for the job, she would have said no in a heartbeat.

But none of it is nothing, either. And all of it is still hers. The company kept the position. It did not get to keep what she built while trying to earn it.

* * *

Here is where I want to leave the contract.

You were taught a deal in which effort buys outcomes. It was taught to you by people who loved you, it was mostly true, and it carried you a long way. But it was never the whole truth, and there is no shame in discovering that as an adult. Everyone who aims at anything that matters discovers it sooner or later.

The truth is less tidy, and kinder. Your effort is real, and it is the one part of the story that belongs entirely to you. It is also one force among several. The wind is real too. So are other people's choices. So, if you believe in it, is whatever is written.

The rest of this book is about how to live inside that truth without becoming either the person who blames herself for every loss or the person who stops trying altogether. There is a third way to stand, and the archer knows it. She draws with everything she has. She lets go. And wherever the arrow lands, she does not hand her worth to the wind.

For your quiver

No farmer has ever believed that plowing guarantees rain. Every farmer plows.

Practice. Write down three things you once expected life, work or love to give you if you did your part. Next to each, write what kind of promise it really was: a commitment someone actually made to you, a reasonable expectation, or a deep and honest wish. Notice how many of your heaviest disappointments came from treating a wish as if it were a commitment.

Chapter 2: Sweat is not a strategy

There is an old story about two woodcutters. It turns up in many countries and many languages, which is usually a sign that a story is true in the way that matters.

The two men agree to a contest: whoever cuts more wood by sunset wins. The first woodcutter is famous for his strength. He starts at dawn and never stops. Every time he glances across the clearing, he sees the second man sitting down, and every time he sees it, he swings harder. By midday his shoulders are burning. By afternoon his hands are bleeding. He keeps going, because that is what champions do.

At sunset they count. The second man has cut nearly twice as much.

"I don't understand," says the first woodcutter. "Every hour I looked over, and every hour you were resting."

"I wasn't resting," says the second. "I was sharpening my axe."

The story is often dressed up with a famous name. You may have seen a line credited to Abraham Lincoln about spending most of your time on a tree sharpening the axe first. Nobody has ever found evidence that he said it. Good ideas often borrow celebrities so they can travel further.

I start here because before we can talk honestly about luck or destiny, we have to be honest about effort. And the most important honest thing to say about effort is this: *hard work* is two different things wearing one coat.

* * *

The first thing is strain. Hours at the desk. Early alarms. Being tired. Sacrifice. When people say "I worked so hard," this is usually what they mean, and they are telling the truth.

The second thing is aim. Effort that targets the specific skill that decides the result, and that changes in response to feedback. This kind of work is quieter and less dramatic. It sometimes involves stopping to think, which from the outside can look exactly like resting. It is the sharpening of the axe.

The two often travel together, but they are not the same thing. When they come apart, a person can pour years of strain into a goal and get very little aim in return.

The psychologist Anders Ericsson spent his career studying how people become excellent. In a well-known study published in 1993, he and his colleagues looked at violin students at a music academy in Berlin. The best students had not simply played more. They had spent more time in what Ericsson called *deliberate practice*: working alone, on the hardest passages, at the edge of their ability, with a clear goal and immediate feedback. Playing a piece you already know from beginning to end feels like practice. Playing the same four difficult bars forty times, slowly, until the mistake disappears, *is* practice.

Ericsson's work was later squeezed into a popular slogan, the "ten thousand hour rule," which promised that anyone could master anything with enough hours. Ericsson himself spent

years objecting to it. The number of hours was never the point. The kind of hours was the point.

* * *

It is also worth knowing how far practice goes, because the honest answer is more interesting than the slogan.

In 2014, the psychologists Brooke Macnamara, David Hambrick and Frederick Oswald pulled together the results of 88 studies that measured both how much people practiced and how well they performed. They wanted to know how much of the difference between performers could be explained by the difference in their practice.

The answer depended enormously on the field. In games like chess, practice accounted for about 26 percent of the differences between people. In music, about 21 percent. In sports, about 18 percent. In education, about 4 percent. In professions, less than 1 percent.

These numbers are easy to misread, so let me handle them carefully. They do not mean that practice is responsible for 18 percent of an athlete's success. They describe how much of the *spread* between people tracks the spread in their practice, across the people in those studies. And the remaining spread is not simply luck. It includes the age people started, how quickly they learn, what their bodies or minds were already suited to, the quality of their coaching and a hundred other things nobody measured.

But the broad message is clear. Practice matters, sometimes a great deal, and practice is not the whole story. In fields with fixed rules and fast feedback, like chess or tennis, it explains more. In

the shifting, noisy worlds of school and work, where feedback is slow and the rules keep changing, it explains much less.

I find that strangely comforting. If you have worked hard and not yet reached the top of your field, there are many possible explanations, and "you are lazy" is only one of them, and usually not the most likely one. It also means that in most of real life, the *amount* of effort is a weaker lever than we think, and the *direction* of effort is a stronger one.

* * *

Here is an example I think about often.

Two students prepare for the same exam. The first reads her notes four times, slowly, with a highlighter. By the fourth reading everything looks familiar, and she feels ready. The second reads her notes once, then spends the rest of her time closing the book and testing herself: writing down everything she can remember, checking what she missed, trying again.

The second student's evening feels worse. It is frustrating to discover how much you have forgotten. The first student's evening feels better. Familiarity feels like knowledge.

In 2006, the psychologists Henry Roediger and Jeffrey Karpicke ran a version of this experiment. Students who repeatedly reread a passage felt more confident, and on a test a few minutes later they did fine. But a week later, the students who had tested themselves remembered considerably more. The rereaders had worked just as hard. Their effort was simply pointed at the feeling of knowing instead of at knowing.

Notice how easy it would be for the first student, if she failed, to say, "I studied so hard and it made no difference." She would

be telling the truth about her effort. She would be wrong about what it meant.

The same pattern shows up far from any classroom. A shopkeeper works sixteen hours a day behind the counter and never once asks why customers walk past his door to the shop across the road. A footballer runs extra laps every evening while the weakness that keeps her off the team is her first touch. A job seeker sends the same unchanged CV to two hundred companies. Each of them is working hard. Each of them is mostly practicing the habit of working hard.

* * *

There is a trap here that catches the most sincere people, and the harder you are willing to work, the more likely you are to fall into it.

When something is not working, the natural response of a hardworking person is to do *more* of it. More hours. More applications. More pressure. More sacrifice. It feels like the honorable choice. Doing less, or stopping to question the method, feels like giving up.

But if the method is flawed, more of it only produces the same result faster. Two hundred identical applications are not twice as diligent as one hundred. They may be the same mistake made at scale.

The woodcutter with bleeding hands was not lazy. He was the hardest worker in the clearing. His problem was that every swing of a dull axe felt to him like proof of commitment. He could not see that the commitment itself had become the obstacle.

Persistence needs feedback as much as it needs courage. A method deserves your loyalty only while it is earning your

confidence.

Some people need to hear the opposite message, and I will not pretend otherwise. Some people really are drifting, avoiding, waiting for a motivation that never arrives. For them, the next step is simply to start, and to keep going on the days they do not feel like it. If that is you, you probably know it already.

But I have noticed that the people who lie awake asking whether their effort means anything are rarely the drifters. They are usually already working past the point of exhaustion. For them, *try harder* is the least useful advice in the world. What they need is permission to stop, look at the axe and ask a few uncomfortable questions.

* * *

When I am working hard and getting nowhere, these are the questions I have learned to ask.

What actually decides this? Not what feels important, but what the person on the other side of the table, the exam, the customer or the market actually rewards. An interview may reward clear stories about past work far more than knowledge of the company's history. A business may live or die on one customer problem the owner keeps avoiding because building the product is more fun. Find the deciding skill and aim there.

Where is my feedback? Feedback is information about the gap between what you did and what you were trying to do. It can come from a coach, a practice test, a rejected draft with comments, a recording of yourself, a customer who left, a friend who will tell you the truth. Effort without feedback is archery in the dark. You can draw beautifully for years and never learn where your arrows are going.

What will I do differently next time? If the honest answer is "nothing," you are not practicing. You are repeating.

Can I keep this pace? Hardworking people avoid this question more than any other, because it sounds like weakness.

* * *

Let me stay with that last question, because our culture has made something strange out of tiredness.

Somewhere along the way, exhaustion became a badge. We tell each other how little we slept as though it were a qualification. We admire the person who never takes a holiday, who answers emails at midnight, who has not seen his children awake all week. Exhaustion feels like proof that we are serious, that we deserve to win, that if the result does not come it will at least not be our fault.

But exhaustion is a cost, not a contribution.

A tired mind learns more slowly, decides worse and notices less. A tired body gets ill. A tired person becomes harder to be around, which closes doors that a rested person would have walked through without noticing. Most of what makes effort effective, the noticing, the adjusting, the patience to sit with a hard problem, the sudden idea in the shower, depends on having something left in the tank.

There is a hidden cost too. When we pour everything into one goal, the rest of life starves: friendships, health, family, faith, joy. If the goal succeeds, we sometimes look around and find we have won a prize in an empty house. If it fails, there is nothing to fall back on. The goal was carrying the whole weight of our life, and when it breaks, everything breaks with it.

I am not telling you to stop working hard. I am telling you that a bow needs tension and rest, and an archer who never unstrings it will one day find it has lost its spring.

* * *

So where does this leave Sara?

If she were my friend, after she had grieved for a few days, I would sit with her and ask some of these questions. Not to suggest the rejection was her fault; it may not have been, and she may never know. But because the next attempt is coming, and the next attempt is the one place where she has real power.

What decided that final round? She can ask. Some companies will tell you, if you ask politely and specifically. She can ask her two contacts what the final interviews tend to reward. She can practice with someone who interrupts her and pushes back, which is far closer to the real thing than the bathroom mirror ever was. She can look at the parts of her preparation that felt good and ask whether they built anything, or whether, like the highlighted notes, they only made her feel ready.

And she can rest. Two years of single-minded wanting is a long time. She has earned a few weeks of doing something else.

None of this guarantees the next job. Nothing will. But it changes the odds, and changing the odds was what effort was for all along. Work like an archer, not like someone beating the ground with a stick.

For your quiver

Exhaustion is a cost, not a contribution.

Practice. Choose one goal you are working hard on and write four short answers. What actually decides success here? Where can I get honest feedback? What will I do differently in the next attempt? What pace could I keep for a whole year? If any answer is “I don’t know,” that is your next task.

Chapter 3: The ground under the ladder

In January 1985, a Canadian psychologist named Roger Barnsley went to an ice hockey game in Lethbridge, Alberta, with his wife Paula. It was a junior league game, the Lethbridge Broncos, the kind of team where talented teenagers try to catch the eye of professional scouts.

Paula was flipping through the printed program, which listed every player's date of birth. She noticed something odd. An extraordinary number of the players had been born in January, February or March. Very few had been born late in the year.

Roger was curious enough to check. He and his colleagues gathered birth dates for players across Canada's elite junior leagues and the National Hockey League. The pattern held. The closer a boy's birthday fell to the start of the year, the more likely he was to reach the top levels of the sport.

Nobody believes that the month of your birth makes you better at hockey. The explanation was simpler, and more troubling.

Canadian youth hockey grouped children by calendar year, with a cut-off on the first of January. A boy born on January 2 and a boy born on December 30 of the same year played in the same age group. At nine years old, that is almost a full year of growth, coordination and confidence. The January boy is bigger

and faster, so the coaches pick him for the better team. On the better team he gets better coaching, more games and more time on the ice. By twelve he really is better. By sixteen he is much better. The coaches were not wrong. They picked the best players they could see.

What they could not see was that a small, accidental head start had been fed and watered for a decade until it grew into a real difference in skill.

The research has been repeated many times since, in other sports and in schools, and the size of the effect varies a great deal from place to place. But the lesson of that hockey program has never left me. Every one of those players trained hard. They all got up in the dark for early practice. And some of them were training on ground that had been raised for them, without anyone noticing, before they ever picked up a stick.

* * *

The wind does not wait for us to pick up the bow. It starts blowing on the day we are born.

We do not choose our parents, our country, our first language or the century we arrive in. We do not choose whether we were born healthy, whether there were books in the house, whether our family could afford for us to work for free for a year to gain experience. We do not choose whether the people with power in our society look at our names, faces or accents with warmth or with suspicion.

In the early 2000s, two economists, Marianne Bertrand and Sendhil Mullainathan, ran an experiment that is still quoted wherever people study hiring. They answered real job advertisements in Boston and Chicago with thousands of invented

résumés. Some résumés carried names that sounded white, such as Emily or Greg. Others carried names that sounded African American, such as Lakisha or Jamal. In every other respect, the names were assigned at random to résumés of matched quality.

The résumés with white-sounding names received about 50 percent more calls for interviews.

No one in that experiment was lazy. No one had failed to prepare. By design, the candidates were equally qualified on paper. Yet half of them started the race several steps behind the line, for a reason that had nothing to do with their effort and nothing to do with chance either. It had to do with the choices of the people reading the paper.

I want to handle this study carefully. It was carried out in particular cities, in one country, at one point in time, and it cannot diagnose any single rejection; most rejected applicants never learn why. But it shows something we should all be willing to see. Sometimes the ground under the ladder is uneven because of what people do, not just because of what happens.

* * *

There is a name for the way small advantages grow into large ones. Sociologists call it *cumulative advantage*. The sociologist Robert Merton first described it in 1968 while studying scientists. When a famous scientist and an unknown one made similar discoveries, the famous one tended to receive most of the credit. That credit brought more fame, which brought more funding and better students, which led to more discoveries, which brought more credit. An early lead did not just persist. It compounded.

Once you see cumulative advantage, you see it everywhere. The child who reads a little earlier enjoys reading more, so she

reads more, so she learns faster. The restaurant that gets a few good early reviews gets more customers, which brings more reviews. The applicant with one famous name on her CV gets the interview that gets her the next famous name.

A team of economists led by Alex Bell and Raj Chetty found a striking version of this in the United States. They linked the records of over a million inventors to their family backgrounds. Children born into the richest 1 percent of families were about ten times as likely to grow up to become inventors as children from the bottom half. And the gap was not simply about ability. Among children who had scored at the very top of their class in maths at age eight or nine, those from wealthy families were still far more likely to become inventors than equally gifted children from poorer families. The researchers called the missing inventors "lost Einsteins": people who had the talent but never met the opportunity.

None of this means that the people who benefit did not work. Usually they worked very hard. The January hockey players trained as hard as anyone. The famous scientist earned her first success. The point is that their work was multiplied by something they did not create. Their effort was a seed, and they happened to plant it in good soil, in a sunny spot, in a wet year.

A fair account of any achievement includes the ground the ladder stood on.

* * *

Warren Buffett, one of the richest people of the last century, has spent decades repeating a phrase I wish more successful people would use. He calls it the *ovarian lottery*. He has pointed out, again and again, that he was born in the United States, in 1930, as

a white man, at the very moment when his particular gift, an unusual talent for judging the value of businesses, happened to be one of the most richly rewarded skills on earth. He worked hard, and he says so. He also says that the same mind and the same effort, born into another time or place, would have counted for far less.

There is something deeply attractive about a person who can say that. The economist Robert Frank, who wrote a whole book about success and luck, argues that people who acknowledge the role of luck in their lives tend to be more generous, and are often better liked, than people who insist they did it all themselves. It makes sense. Someone who sees their own luck can see other people's bad luck too. Someone who believes they made themselves usually believes that everyone else made themselves as well, including the people who are struggling.

* * *

Now I need to warn you about the opposite mistake, because once you have seen how much the ground matters, it is easy to fall off the other side.

If birthdays shape hockey careers, and names shape interviews, and parents' income shapes who becomes an inventor, then perhaps effort really is a joke. Perhaps everything is decided before we start. Perhaps the people who succeed were simply handed it, the people who struggle were simply robbed, and nothing any of us does makes much difference.

This sounds tough-minded. It is really just the old contract turned upside down. It assumes that if effort is not *everything*, it must be *nothing*.

Look again at the hockey players. Being born in January raised a boy's odds of reaching the top. It did not put him there. Most January boys never played professional hockey; most of them, like most of everyone, played for a few years and then grew up and did other things. And some December boys, smaller and slower at nine, kept training, kept loving the game, kept showing up, and made it anyway, often after years of being overlooked. They had to climb a taller ladder. Some of them climbed it.

The honest picture is this. Circumstances set your starting height and the steepness of the climb. Effort still decides a great deal about how far you rise from wherever you begin. Your starting point was luck. Your direction is not only luck.

* * *

There is one more distinction that matters, and it is often blurred.

Some of the wind really is luck: an illness nobody could predict, a recession that arrives the year you graduate, a flood that takes the harvest, the one person who could have helped you moving to another city. Nobody did this to you. It simply happened.

But some of what we call bad luck is not luck at all. It is a barrier that was put there, and is kept there, by people. A manager who will not hire a woman. A rule that shuts out people from a certain background. A family that will not let a daughter study. A system that rewards connections over competence.

When we call these things luck, we do two kinds of damage. We hide the responsibility of the people who could change them. And we tell the person facing them that there is nothing to do but endure, when sometimes a great deal can be done: by orga-

nizing, by speaking up, by finding allies, by building something new, by changing the rules for the next person even if they cannot be changed in time for you.

Not everything called bad luck is luck. Some of it has an author. And your effort does not have to belong only to your own climb. Some of it can go into repairing the ladder.

* * *

Let me go back to Sara for a moment.

There is a detail she did not mention, even to herself. The previous summer, Daniel had done an unpaid internship at a firm that worked closely with the company they both applied to. Sara could not have done an unpaid internship. Her family needed her salary, and she spent that summer at an accounting office with nothing glamorous about it at all.

Does that mean Daniel did not deserve the job? No. He worked hard during that internship and learned real things there. Does it mean Sara lost only because of money? No. She will never know exactly why the decision went the way it did, and deciding that she does would be another kind of story.

But it does mean that when Sara's inner voice writes its verdict, *you just were not good enough*, it is leaving something out. The two of them were not standing on the same ground. A fair account has to include that. Not as an excuse, and not as a grievance to carry forever, but as part of the truth.

* * *

What can a person actually do with all this?

It starts with an honest map. Not a map of how you wish things were, and not a map of how motivational posters say

things are, but a map of your real situation.

What do you have? Skills, people who care about you, health, time, savings, a language, a network, a roof, a faith or philosophy that holds you up. Some of it you earned. Some was given. All of it counts.

What is in your way? Some obstacles you can change yourself. Some can be negotiated. Some belong to the wind and can only be waited out or worked around. Some are barriers held in place by others and may need more than one person to move.

Where can you get help? Proud, hardworking people skip this question more than any other. The myth of the self-made person makes asking for help feel like cheating. It is not. Everyone who ever climbed anything was helped, whether or not they noticed.

When you draw this map, two things happen. First, some of the shame lifts. You can see that your struggle is not simply a measure of your character. Second, and this surprises people, the map usually shows more room to act than you expected. Never unlimited room. But room.

That is where the archer stands: not on perfect ground, but on real ground, with a real bow, in a real wind. Knowing exactly where she stands is the first part of aiming well.

For your quiver

Your starting point was luck. Your direction is not only luck.

Practice. Draw four boxes on a page. In the first, write what you have: your resources, earned or given. In the second, the obstacles you can change yourself. In the third, the obstacles you can only wait out or work around. In the fourth, the barriers that would need other people to move. Then circle one thing in the first box that you have not been using.

Part Two: The wind

On luck: why it seems to love the hardworking, why it fools us, and how to judge a choice when chance has a vote

The wind was blowing long before you picked up the bow.

Chapter 4: Why luck loves the hardworking

I began this book with a pattern I noticed so often that I stopped calling it coincidence: when I work hard, my luck seems to work hard too.

I am in very large company. One of the most repeated sayings in the English language is some version of the idea that the harder you work, the luckier you get. You will find it on office walls and under photographs of sunrise runs. It is usually credited to Thomas Jefferson.

Jefferson never said it. The researchers at Monticello, his former home, have looked carefully and found no evidence that he said or wrote anything like it. People who trace the history of famous sayings have found earlier versions in American publications of the 1920s, and a punchier version in the mouths of professional golfers around 1960. Nobody knows who said it first. It seems to have been discovered by many people independently, because so many people felt it to be true.

I love that history, because it is a small lesson in luck all by itself. A saying about how luck rewards effort was carried into fame by a lucky accident: somebody attached it to a famous

name, and the name made it travel. The unknown people who actually worked the idea out got no credit at all.

But the history does not answer the real question. Is the pattern true? And if it is, *why*? Luck is supposed to be random. Why would something random favor the people who work?

* * *

In September 1928, a Scottish scientist named Alexander Fleming came back to his laboratory in London after a summer holiday. Before leaving, he had stacked a pile of glass dishes in which he had been growing bacteria, and now he began sorting through them. On one dish he noticed a patch of mold. That was nothing special; contaminated dishes were a daily nuisance, and most people would have thrown it straight into the washing tub.

But Fleming noticed something else. Around the mold there was a clear ring where the bacteria had died.

That dish led to penicillin, and penicillin went on to save more lives than anyone can count. It is one of the most famous strokes of luck in the history of science. The mold spore that drifted onto that dish, probably from another laboratory in the same building, was pure chance. So was the summer weather that let the mold and the bacteria grow in exactly the right way.

Here is the part that was not luck. For years before that morning, Fleming had been hunting for substances that could kill bacteria. Years earlier, he had discovered an antibacterial substance in human tears and mucus, which taught him exactly what such an effect might look like on a glass dish. When the accident arrived, it arrived in front of one of the very few people in London whose mind had been shaped, by years of work, to understand what it meant.

Seventy-four years earlier, the French scientist Louis Pasteur had told an audience in the city of Lille that, in the world of observation, chance helps only the minds that are ready for it. Notice what Pasteur did not claim. He did not say preparation creates chance. The mold would have landed on that dish whether or not Fleming was prepared. What preparation did was turn an accident into an opportunity. Without it, the same dish would have been washed and forgotten.

Preparation cannot create the accident. It decides whether the accident becomes an opportunity.

* * *

In the 1990s, a British psychologist named Richard Wiseman decided to study luck the way a scientist studies anything else. He placed advertisements asking for people who considered themselves exceptionally lucky or exceptionally unlucky, and over the following years he interviewed and tested hundreds of them.

One of his experiments is among the most revealing small experiments I know.

Wiseman handed each volunteer a newspaper and asked them to count the photographs inside. That was the whole task. On average, the people who described themselves as unlucky took about two minutes. The people who described themselves as lucky took a few seconds.

The reason was printed on the second page. Taking up half the page, in letters more than two inches high, was a message telling the reader to stop counting, because the newspaper contained 43 photographs. It was staring everyone in the face. The unlucky people tended to miss it. The lucky people tended to see it.

Then, just for fun, Wiseman placed a second large message halfway through the paper. It told readers to stop counting, tell the experimenter they had seen the message, and win $250. Again, the unlucky people tended to miss it. They were too busy counting photographs.

When Wiseman looked more closely at his two groups, he found that the "unlucky" volunteers tended to be more tense and anxious. Anxiety narrows attention. It makes us focus hard on the task in front of us, which sounds like a virtue, but it also blinds us to anything we were not expecting. The "lucky" volunteers tended to be more relaxed and open. They also tended to meet more people, to talk to strangers, to vary their routines. They put themselves in front of more chances, and they were more likely to notice a chance when it appeared.

His conclusion was that lucky people are not, for the most part, people to whom more random good things happen. They are people who are better at noticing and creating chance opportunities, and better at making something of the bad ones.

One gentle note of caution. Wiseman's volunteers *described* themselves as lucky or unlucky, and some of the difference between them may be about how they tell the story of their lives, not only about how their lives went. But the newspaper is hard to argue with. Two groups of people looked at the same pages. Only one group saw the message.

* * *

There is one more piece of research that explains where much of our luck comes from.

In the early 1970s, a young sociologist named Mark Granovetter interviewed people in a Boston suburb who had re-

cently changed jobs. He asked how they had found their new positions. Many had found them through personal contacts, which nobody found surprising. What surprised everyone was *which* contacts. More often than not, the useful contact was not a close friend or family member. It was an acquaintance: someone they saw only occasionally or rarely. A former colleague. A friend of a friend. Someone from a club they had stopped going to.

Granovetter called this *the strength of weak ties*. Your close friends mostly know what you know and meet whom you meet. Your acquaintances live in other circles, hear about other openings and can carry your name into rooms you will never enter. Decades later, in 2022, researchers working with data from millions of LinkedIn users ran a large experiment and found a similar pattern: moderately weak connections were the ones most likely to help people move to new jobs.

This matters for anyone who works hard in silence. A great deal of what we call luck travels through people, and especially through people at the edge of our lives. They can only carry what they know about.

* * *

So why does luck seem to love the people who work hard? After a long time with this question, I believe there are four reasons, and none of them requires magic.

The first is *exposure*. The wind can only carry arrows that have been released. A person who sends out ten applications has ten chances for something unexpected to happen. A person who sends out one has one. A writer who finishes five stories has five tickets in the draw; a writer still polishing the first page of the first story has none. Hard work, in its most basic form, puts more

of your life into contact with chance. More contact means more good accidents, along with more bad ones.

A software developer named Jason Roberts once described this as your *luck surface area*: the more you do, and the more people you tell about what you are doing, the larger the surface on which luck can land. Lucky breaks rarely find people who are hidden.

The second is *readiness*. Opportunities come to many people. Only some can use what arrives. The musician who has practiced every day for three years can step in when the band's guitarist falls ill on the night of a big show. Her friend who has been meaning to practice cannot. Both received the same phone call. Only one had something to say yes with.

The third is *visibility*. When you work seriously at something, other people notice. They remember you. They mention you to someone else. A teacher recommends you. A former colleague forwards your name. A customer tells a friend. Much of what we call luck arrives through other people, and other people can only bring opportunities to someone they know is looking.

The fourth is *attention*, the newspaper effect. When you are deeply engaged in a field, your mind keeps scanning, without being asked, for anything relevant to it. You notice the article, the overheard conversation, the strange result on a glass dish. Someone who is not engaged walks straight past the same signs, because they mean nothing to them.

Put these four together and the pattern that began this book makes sense. Hard work does not bend the laws of chance. It widens the space in which opportunity can find you, and it makes you ready to recognize and use what arrives. Work does not summon luck. It builds a place for luck to land.

* * *

Now the honest part, because if I told you only this half of the story I would be repeating the old contract in a cleverer coat.

First, our memories are not neutral. When a lucky break arrives after a season of hard work, it makes a great story, and we keep it. It confirms something we want to believe about ourselves. We tend to forget the lucky breaks that came when we had done nothing to deserve them, because they make a less satisfying story. And we tend to stop telling the stories of the long seasons of hard work that produced no luck at all.

Second, we are poor judges of how much control we have. In 1975, the psychologist Ellen Langer ran a simple experiment with lottery tickets in an office. Some employees chose their own ticket. Others were handed one. Later, when asked how much they would want to sell their ticket, the people who had chosen their own asked for roughly four times as much. The odds were identical. Choosing simply made the ticket feel more theirs, and more likely to win. Langer called this the *illusion of control*. It is part of why we feel, after a lucky break, that our effort must have caused it.

Third, luck often has a human face. When we look back on our good fortune, we tend to tell it as a story of our own preparation meeting a lucky moment. We forget the person who mentioned our name, the teacher who stayed late, the stranger who held the door, the parent who paid for the course. Those people were not luck. They were generosity. Leaving them out makes the story more flattering and less true.

Fourth, and this brings us back to the people at the start of the book: exposure, readiness, visibility and attention all improve your odds. None of them can choose what arrives. A prepared

musician may never get that phone call. A brilliant scientist may spend a whole career at the bench and never see the clear ring around the mold. The lucky people in Wiseman's study still had bad days. Work can widen the space where opportunity finds you. It cannot decide what walks through the door.

* * *

There is a way of holding all of this that I have found steadying.

Instead of thinking of luck as a reward that hard work earns, think of it as weather. You cannot control the weather. But you can decide whether you are standing outside when it is good. You can make sure your field is plowed before the rain. You can learn to read the sky well enough to know when to plant. And when a storm comes that no preparation could have prevented, you can know that the storm was not a verdict on your farming.

This way of thinking keeps both halves of the truth. Your effort is real, and it really does tilt the odds; that is why you noticed the pattern in the first place. And the weather is real, and owes you nothing; that is why the pattern has exceptions that break people's hearts.

Effort does not buy good luck. It buys more weather. And over a lifetime, a person who stands in more weather, with a plowed field and open eyes, tends to catch more rain.

For your quiver

Work does not summon luck. It builds a place for luck to land.

Practice. Keep a luck log for two weeks. Each evening, write one line about what you did toward what matters, one unexpected good thing, one unexpected bad thing and any help you received. Record disappointments as carefully as surprises. At the end, read it all in one sitting and notice where your luck actually came from, and how much of it came through people.

Chapter 5: The planes that came back

During the Second World War, American and British bombers flew over Europe every day, and every day many of them did not return. Armor could save them, but armor is heavy. A plane covered in it would be too slow to fly its mission and too thirsty to make it home. So the question was where to put a limited amount of protection.

The military did the sensible thing. It looked at the planes that came back and recorded where they had been hit. The bullet holes clustered in certain places, along the wings and the body of the aircraft. The obvious conclusion was to reinforce those areas. Put the armor where the holes are.

In New York, a small group of mathematicians was working on problems for the military at Columbia University. One of them was Abraham Wald, a Hungarian-born statistician who had fled Europe before the war. Wald saw what everyone else had missed.

These were the planes that *came back*.

The holes showed where a plane could be hit and still make it home. The places where the returning planes had few holes, around the engines for example, were not places that rarely got hit. They were places where a hit tended to bring the plane down,

so those planes were never in the hangar to be counted. The armor, Wald argued, should go where the holes were not.

Historians have since pointed out that Wald's real work was more technical than the legend; he wrote a series of mathematical memos about how to estimate a plane's weak points from the damage on the survivors. But the heart of the legend is true, and it has become the most famous example of what statisticians call *survivorship bias*: drawing conclusions from the cases that survived some process, while forgetting the ones that did not.

The planes that never returned wrote nothing in the report. And once you understand that, you start to notice the missing planes everywhere.

* * *

A business magazine profiles the founder who dropped out of university and became a billionaire. It does not profile the many people who dropped out, started companies and went bankrupt. The interview with the actor who moved to the city with nothing and refused to give up does not include the actors who moved to the city with nothing, refused to give up, and are still waiting tables. The successful investor explains his strategy on television. Nobody invites the hundreds who used the same strategy and lost their savings.

These stories are not lies. The founder really did drop out; the actor really did persist. The problem is that the stories arrive without their missing half, so we draw the wrong lesson. We conclude that dropping out, persisting or following that strategy *causes* success, when we have no idea how often it leads to failure.

Think of one of the best-loved success stories of our time. J. K. Rowling's first Harry Potter manuscript was turned down by around a dozen publishers before a small London house took a chance on it. The story is told and retold to young writers as proof that you should never give up.

It is a beautiful story, and I would not take it away from anyone. But Wald would ask a simple question. How many manuscripts were rejected twelve times, then twelve more, then fifty more? Their authors did not give up either. They kept sending the pages out, year after year. We do not hear their stories. They are the planes that did not come back.

Persistence may well be necessary for most kinds of success. That is very different from saying it is enough. The returning planes can teach us the first. They cannot teach us the second. Before you copy a winner, count the people who did the same thing and lost.

* * *

There is a more unsettling question underneath all this. Suppose we could see every failure as well as every success. Would the best work always win?

In 2006, the sociologists Matthew Salganik, Peter Dodds and Duncan Watts tried to find out by building an artificial world. They created a website where more than fourteen thousand people could listen to and download songs by unknown bands. There were forty-eight songs, and none of the participants had heard any of them before.

Some participants were placed in an "independent" world, where they saw only the names of the bands and songs and made up their own minds. The rest were divided into eight separate

worlds, each of which showed participants how many times each song had already been downloaded by others in that world. All eight worlds began identically. Each was a small parallel universe in which the same songs, heard by similar people, competed for attention.

The results were striking. In the worlds where people could see what others were choosing, the popular songs became far more popular and the unpopular ones far less, compared with the independent world. Success became more unequal. It also became much harder to predict. The same song could become a hit in one world and sit in the middle of the pack in another. Early downloads, which were essentially random, snowballed. A small lead at the beginning tended to grow into a large lead at the end.

Quality was not irrelevant. The songs that did best in the independent world rarely did terribly in the social worlds, and the songs that did worst rarely did brilliantly. But across a wide middle range, which song became a hit depended heavily on what happened to be downloaded first.

I want to be fair to this study. It was one experiment, in one artificial music market, two decades ago. It cannot tell us the exact role of chance in any particular career. But it is a serious challenge to the comforting belief that the best work always rises to the top. In a world where people watch each other, and they always do, early luck can be amplified until it looks like destiny.

* * *

The economist Robert Frank, whom we met in Chapter 3, added another piece with a simple computer simulation.

Picture a competition with thousands of entrants. Each entrant has a score for skill and effort, and a much smaller score for

luck. Even when luck counts for only a tiny share of the final result, Frank found, the winner of a large contest is usually *not* the most skilled entrant.

The reason is simple once you see it. When thousands of people compete, the best of them are extremely close together in ability. There is very little daylight between the top hundred. So the small amount of luck, the good day, the favorable judge, the timing, becomes the tie-breaker. It does not take much wind to decide a contest between archers who are all excellent.

This has a strange consequence. The bigger the prize and the fiercer the competition, the more likely it is that the winner was both very good *and* very lucky. The many people who were equally good but less lucky are invisible. And the winner, looking back, will quite naturally explain the victory in terms of skill and effort, because they really were skilled and they really did work hard. Everything they say will be true. It will simply be missing the wind.

* * *

None of this is meant to make you cynical about success, or to take anything away from people who have achieved great things. Most of them earned their place among the finalists through years of work. The point is to see clearly what their stories can and cannot teach.

When you hear a success story, it helps to ask a few quiet questions, the way Wald did in the hangar.

How many people did the same thing and failed? You will usually not know the number. Simply asking the question loosens the story's grip.

What advantages did this person have that the story leaves out? Money, connections, health, timing, a particular city, a particular decade.

What would have happened with a slightly different roll of the dice? If the first investor had said no. If the song had been downloaded fourth instead of first. If the plane had been hit two feet to the left.

Does the person telling the story acknowledge luck? In my experience, the ones who do are often the most trustworthy guides.

These questions do not make success stories useless. They make them honest. A survivor can still teach you a great deal about how to fly. They just cannot promise that their way of flying brings everyone home.

* * *

There is one more hangar where the returning planes are counted, and most of us walk through it every day.

After her rejection, Sara did what so many of us do when we are hurting. She opened her phone and scrolled. And there she found plane after plane that had made it home. A school friend announcing a job at a famous company. A cousin's engagement photographs. A former colleague's promotion. An acquaintance's new house.

What Sara could not see were the planes that did not return. The friend's forty rejections before this one. The cousin's two broken engagements. The colleague turned down for the same promotion twice. The acquaintance's debt. People rarely post their storms, only their landings. So the screen gives you a picture of a world in which everyone else's arrows hit the target and only yours fall into the grass.

That picture is false. Not because the posts are false, but because the hangar is missing its other half.

So when other people's success makes your own failure feel sharper, remember Wald. Look at the holes. Admire the planes that made it home; many of them flew through terrible weather. Then ask, gently, where the others are. You will not find them. But knowing they exist is enough to stop the screen from lying to you about your own life.

For your quiver

Before you copy a winner, count the people who did the same thing and lost.

Practice. Choose one success story that has shaped how you think, about a famous person or someone you know. Write down three things that are missing from it: people who did the same thing and failed, advantages the story does not mention, and moments where a different roll of the dice would have changed the ending. Then ask what lesson is still standing.

Chapter 6: The old man at the frontier

There is a story Chinese parents have been telling their children for more than two thousand years. Its oldest written version is in a book called the *Huainanzi*, compiled at the court of a Han dynasty prince in the second century before the common era. I will tell it in my own words, keeping close to the old version.

An old man lived near the northern frontier, where China met the lands of the nomadic horsemen. One day his horse ran away across the border. His neighbors came to console him. What terrible luck, they said.

The old man shrugged. Who knows, he said, whether this might turn out to be a blessing?

Some months later the horse came back, and it was not alone. It had brought with it a magnificent horse from the nomads' herds. The neighbors came to congratulate him. What wonderful luck!

Who knows, said the old man, whether this might turn out to be a misfortune?

His son loved to ride, and he took the new horse out often. One day he was thrown and badly broke his leg. He would walk with a limp for the rest of his life. The neighbors came again. What terrible luck.

Who knows, said the old man, whether this might turn out to be a blessing?

A year later the nomads invaded in force. Every able-bodied young man in the region was called up to fight, and nine out of ten of them died in the war. Because of his leg, the old man's son was not taken. Father and son both survived.

The story ends there. It does not tell us what happened next, and that is part of its point. There is always a next.

In Chinese, the story survives as a short saying people still use when something bad happens: the old man at the frontier lost his horse, and who could know it was not a blessing? In modern English retellings, the old man's reply is often shortened to a single word. *Maybe.*

* * *

I want to be very clear about what this story does *not* mean, because it is often misused.

It does not mean that every misfortune is secretly good fortune. The son's broken leg was not good. It hurt, and it changed his life. If you had asked him, I suspect he would have chosen two good legs and taken his chances with the war. And the story says nothing about the families of the nine young men in ten who did not come home. For them, there was no happy turn at all.

The old man never said the runaway horse was good. He never called the broken leg a gift. He said *who knows?* That is a completely different statement. He was not putting a cheerful label on events. He was refusing to put a final label on them at all.

The old man did not say it was good. He said it was not finished.

This is the first great lesson the story carries, and I think it is one of the most useful things a human being can learn. We call things luck too early. We label an event as good or bad fortune in the moment it happens, when we can see only a small part of what it will lead to. Then we feel the full weight of the label as though it were final. But events keep unfolding. The meaning of almost everything that happens to us is still being written for years afterward.

* * *

The psychologist Daniel Kahneman, who won a Nobel Prize for his work on how people make judgments, described a moment that changed his own thinking. It was not a parable. It happened while he was teaching flight instructors in the Israeli Air Force.

He was explaining a principle from the psychology of learning: rewarding good performance works better than punishing mistakes. One instructor objected. In his experience, he said, it was the other way round. When he praised a cadet for an excellent maneuver, the next attempt was usually worse. When he shouted at a cadet for a terrible one, the next attempt was usually better. So, he concluded, praise makes people worse and criticism makes them better.

The instructor was describing something real. He was simply wrong about the cause.

Any single performance, Kahneman realized, is a mixture of skill and luck. A cadet's skill does not change much from one landing to the next. Luck does: a gust of wind, a moment of distraction, a lucky correction. An exceptionally good landing usually means skill was helped, that time, by some good luck. Next time the luck will probably be more ordinary, so the result will

probably be less impressive, whatever the instructor says. An exceptionally bad landing usually means skill was hurt by bad luck, so the next one will probably be better, again whatever the instructor says.

Statisticians call this *regression to the mean*. Extreme results tend to be followed by less extreme ones, because the luck that made them extreme does not usually repeat. The instructor had been watching the wind and believing he was watching the power of his own voice.

Kahneman later summed up the role of luck in a pair of short formulas. Success, he wrote, is talent plus luck. Great success is a little more talent and a lot more luck.

* * *

Regression to the mean is not just a curiosity for statisticians. It shapes, without our noticing, how we judge ourselves and other people.

You have an unusually brilliant week at work and start to believe that is who you really are. Then the next week is ordinary, and it feels like decline. You do terribly in an exam and decide you are hopeless at the subject. Then the next exam goes better, and you credit your new study method, when part of the improvement was simply the bad luck of the first day not repeating. A shop has a record month and the owner hires two new staff; the next month is average and he panics. A striker scores in five matches in a row and is called a genius; then the goals stop and he is called finished.

Sports fans even have a name for one version of this: the magazine cover jinx. An athlete has an extraordinary season and lands on the cover of a famous sports magazine. The next season

is less spectacular. Is the magazine cursed? No. To make the cover, an athlete usually needs an exceptional season, and exceptional seasons usually include some good luck. The next season, the luck evens out.

This is humbling and freeing at the same time. Your best moment was probably not the full measure of your ability, and your worst moment probably was not either. A single result contains wind. A pattern over time contains you. Judge yourself by the pattern, not by the most dramatic point in it.

* * *

There is a second lesson in the frontier story, and it concerns how much the "big" events of our lives actually change us.

In 1978, a team of psychologists led by Philip Brickman did a small and unusual study. They interviewed people who had recently won large prizes in the Illinois state lottery. They also interviewed people who had been paralyzed in serious accidents, and a comparison group of people who had experienced neither.

The study was small, and later research has debated and refined it. But its findings were startling at the time. Once the excitement settled, the lottery winners were not much happier than the comparison group. They even reported taking *less* pleasure in everyday things: chatting with a friend, hearing a joke, eating breakfast. Winning had raised the bar for what felt good. The accident victims were, on average, less happy than the comparison group. But they were not nearly as unhappy as most people would predict. Their ratings of their present happiness still sat above the middle of the scale, far from the despair that outsiders imagined for them.

We will come back to this idea later, because it matters enormously to anyone who has just lost something they wanted. For now, notice what it says about luck. The events we label as life-changing fortune often change us less, and more briefly, than we expect. The events we label as life-ruining misfortune also often change us less, and more briefly, than we fear. Human beings adapt. We are more resilient, and harder to satisfy, than our labels assume.

The old man at the frontier seems to have known this. He never climbed too high or fell too low. Not because he did not care about his horse or his son, but because he knew the story was not over and that he would still be himself at the end of it.

* * *

So what do we do with this?

I am not suggesting that you meet every event with a shrug. That would be strange, and probably impossible. When something good happens, celebrate. When something bad happens, you are allowed to grieve. Feelings are not mistakes.

What I am suggesting is a small change in the words you use, especially the words you use about yourself.

When bad news arrives, the mind rushes to write a final label. *This is a disaster. My life is ruined. It's over. I'm unlucky. This always happens to me.* These are verdicts, and verdicts are written as if the story has ended.

Try putting two words in front of them: *so far*.

So far, this is very bad. That sentence is completely honest. It does not pretend you are fine. But it leaves a door open for what comes next. It is the old man's *who knows* in a form that does not require you to be calm.

When good news arrives, the same two words protect you from the opposite mistake. *So far, this is wonderful.* Celebrate it fully. Just do not build your whole house on it, because the horse that arrived today may throw your son tomorrow.

* * *

Months after her rejection, Sara would take a job at a smaller company, where she would be given far more responsibility, far sooner, than the famous company would ever have given her. We will come back to her story. I mention it here not to tie a bow on her loss, because some days it still stings. I mention it because on the evening she read that email in her kitchen, she was completely certain she knew what it meant.

She did not know. She could not have known. Nobody can, on the evening it happens.

That is what the old man at the frontier understood. Not that every loss becomes a gain; it does not. But that a single event, seen from inside the moment, is one page torn from the middle of a long book. You can feel what is on the page. You cannot yet read the chapter.

For your quiver

The old man did not say it was good. He said it was not finished.

Practice. Think of an event from at least five years ago that you labeled, at the time, as very good or very bad luck. Write down what you believed it meant on the day it happened. Then write down what it actually led to, good and bad. Notice the distance between the two accounts. Finally, take one thing troubling you now and write about it in a sentence that begins with "So far."

Chapter 7: A good decision can lose

On the first of February 2015, in the final seconds of the Super Bowl, the most-watched sporting event in the United States, a football coach named Pete Carroll made a decision that would follow him for the rest of his career.

His team, the Seattle Seahawks, were four points behind the New England Patriots. Twenty-six seconds remained. Seattle had the ball one yard from the end zone, with three chances left to score. On the field was Marshawn Lynch, one of the most powerful runners in the game, famous for carrying the ball through crowds of defenders. Almost everyone watching expected Carroll to hand the ball to Lynch.

Instead, he called a pass. The quarterback threw it. A little-known Patriots defender named Malcolm Butler stepped in front of the receiver and caught it. The game was over. New England won.

The next morning the verdict was close to unanimous. Commentators called it the worst decision in the history of the Super Bowl. Carroll was a fool. He had thrown away a championship.

The poker champion Annie Duke opens her book *Thinking in Bets* with this moment, and she makes an argument that I re-

sisted the first time I heard it. Carroll's decision, she suggests, may not have been bad at all.

There was a logic to it. With little time left and only one timeout, a pass that fell incomplete would stop the clock and leave time for two more attempts. Passes from the one-yard line were rarely intercepted. If the pass had been caught for a touchdown, people would have called Carroll brilliant. If it had fallen incomplete, nobody would remember it; Lynch would have had his chances on the next two plays. Only one of the likely outcomes, and an unlikely one, turned the call into a disaster. That is the one that happened.

Football experts still argue about whether the call was wise. That is fine. My point, and Duke's, is narrower. The *outcome* alone cannot settle it. A good decision can lose. And the world almost always judges the decision by the loss.

* * *

Poker players have a word for this mistake. They call it *resulting*: judging the quality of a decision by the quality of its result.

The mistake is easy to see in poker because the cards make the role of luck so obvious. A player can make exactly the right decision, betting with the best hand, and lose because the last card goes against her. Another player can make a reckless bet with a weak hand and win because the last card goes his way. Over one hand, the reckless player looks clever. Over a thousand hands, the careful player takes his money.

Professional players train themselves, painfully, to stop judging their play by single hands. They review each decision by asking whether it was sound given what they knew at the time, and they let the cards fall where they fall. If they did not, they would

either go mad or start learning the wrong lessons from good luck and bad luck alike.

Most of us, in the rest of life, are not trained this way. We judge our choices entirely by how they turn out.

A doctor chooses the treatment with the best evidence behind it, and the patient has a rare reaction. The family blames the doctor. A farmer plants the crop that has done well in his region for twenty years, and an unusual season ruins it, while his neighbor's careless gamble on a different crop pays off. The village decides the neighbor is wise. A student picks the university course that fits her talents, and the industry it leads to shrinks five years later. Her relatives tell her she should have listened to them.

In every case, the result is real. In every case, the judgment of the decision may be completely wrong.

* * *

Here is a simple picture that has helped me.

Every decision we make, and every result that follows, can land in one of four boxes.

In the first box, a good decision leads to a good result. You prepare carefully for an exam and you pass. This is *deserved success*, the box the old contract promised we would always land in.

In the second box, a good decision leads to a bad result. You take the safe road home and a drunk driver hits you. You choose a stable employer and it collapses. This is *bad luck*.

In the third box, a bad decision leads to a good result. You drive home after drinking and arrive safely. You put your savings on a stranger's tip and it doubles. This is *dumb luck*, and it is dangerous, because it teaches the wrong lesson.

In the fourth box, a bad decision leads to a bad result. This is where honest learning lives, and where real responsibility belongs.

The trouble is that when we look back, we collapse the four boxes into two. Good results must have come from good decisions. Bad results must have come from bad ones. The driver who made it home concludes that he drives fine after a few drinks. The person who chose carefully and lost concludes that she chose badly.

Judge the decision by what you knew, not by what the dice did.

* * *

Let me tell you about Omar. He is a composite, too.

Omar was offered a job at a large company. The salary was good, slightly better than his current one. But during the interviews he noticed things that worried him. The manager he would work for spoke with contempt about people who had left the team. Two former employees he contacted told him, separately, that the department burned through people within a year. The role also pulled him away from the work he wanted to be doing in five years.

Omar took his time. He talked to his wife and to a mentor he trusted. He looked at his savings. He thought about how likely he was to find something better within a few months, and concluded, given the state of the market that spring, that it was reasonably likely. He declined the offer.

Two months later, an economic shock rippled through his industry. Hiring froze almost everywhere. The better job he had expected did not appear. His own company began cutting staff, and

that autumn he was one of them. He spent eight months unemployed.

Throughout those months, people told him, some kindly and some not, that he had made a terrible mistake. What had he been thinking?

Was it a terrible mistake?

Judged by the result, obviously. If he had taken the job, he would have had a salary through the hard months.

Judged as a decision, it is far less obvious. Omar had real reasons for his concerns. He gathered evidence instead of guessing. He sought advice. He considered his finances. The shock that followed was something very few people saw coming. And there is no way to know what would have happened in the job he declined; that company also cut staff later that year, and the newest employees are often the first to go.

Omar may have made a reasonable choice that landed in the second box. He may also have made some genuine mistakes. Perhaps he underestimated the risk of a downturn, or had no backup plan. Those are worth examining. What is not worth doing is concluding, from the bad result alone, that the whole decision was foolish and that he can no longer trust his own judgment.

An outcome is evidence to examine. It is not a verdict on the person who faced it.

* * *

I do not want to swing too far the other way, because “it was just bad luck” can become a hiding place.

Some people use luck as a permanent excuse. Every failure is the market, the boss or the universe. Nothing is ever their re-

sponsibility. That is as much a distortion as the opposite, and just as dangerous, because a person who believes every bad result is bad luck never learns anything.

The goal is not to protect yourself from responsibility. It is to place responsibility accurately. That means separating three things that blur together when we look back.

What did I know at the time? Not what you know now. What was actually available to you then.

What could I have known, with reasonable effort? Sometimes the information was there and you did not look. That is worth learning from.

What could nobody have known? The interception. The economic shock. The mold spore on the dish. These belong to the wind.

When you separate these three, two things happen at once. You become harder on yourself in a useful way, because you can see exactly where you skipped your homework. And you become gentler on yourself in a necessary way, because you can see exactly what was never in your hands.

* * *

There is a practice that some investors, doctors and poker players use, and I think it is one of the most useful habits a thoughtful person can build. It is called a decision journal.

Before an important decision, write down a few things. What you are deciding. Why. What you expect to happen, and how confident you are. What alternatives you considered. What would change your mind. And a date, a few months or a year away, when you will look at it again.

Then make the decision and get on with your life.

When the review date comes, read what you wrote before you knew how things turned out. This is the part that matters most, because our memories are not honest about our past reasoning. Once we know the result, we tend to remember ourselves as more certain, or more doubtful, or wiser, or more foolish than we really were. Psychologists have shown this many times; we will meet the research in Chapter 9. The journal is a letter from your past self that your present self cannot edit.

You will learn two kinds of things from it. Sometimes you will find you made a careful decision and the world simply went the other way, and you can put down the shame. Sometimes you will find you ignored a warning you had actually written down, and you can learn from that specific mistake without condemning your whole character.

* * *

I find the four boxes strangely consoling, and I want to tell you why.

If good decisions always led to good results, every failure would prove a bad decision, and every disappointment would be a judgment on your intelligence, your character or your faith. That is the world the old contract describes. It is a harsh world to live in, because everyone in it eventually fails.

We do not live in that world. We live in one where good decisions can lose and bad decisions can win. It sounds unfair, and in a sense it is. But it also means your worth as a decision-maker, and as a person, cannot be read from any single result. It can only be seen in the way you choose, again and again, across many years and many kinds of weather.

Pete Carroll, for what it is worth, did not stop coaching after that night. He took the criticism, went back to work and kept making decisions. Some of them won. Some of them lost. That is what a career looks like from the inside. It is what a life looks like, too. A bad decision can win once. Only a good one can be repeated on purpose.

For your quiver

Judge the decision by what you knew, not by what the dice did.

Practice. Before your next important decision, write a short note: what you are deciding, why, what you expect, which alternatives you rejected, what would change your mind, and a date to review it. Seal it, on paper or on your phone. When the date comes, compare your reasoning with the result, and sort what happened into what you knew, what you could have known and what nobody could have known.

Part Three: The written page

On destiny: three different questions hiding inside one word

Whatever is written, the bow does not draw itself.

Chapter 8: If the future is fixed, why try?

The word *destiny* hides three different questions, and much of our confusion comes from mixing them up.

The first question is about the future: *if what will happen is already fixed, does my effort make any difference?*

The second is about the past: *why does everything that happened to me feel, looking back, as though it was always going to happen?*

The third is about the present: *how much room do I actually have to choose, given my money, my time and the people who depend on me?*

This chapter takes the first question. The next two chapters take the others. Keeping them apart is half the work, because an answer that is true for one of them can be poison when applied to another.

So here is the first question in its plainest form, the one that started this whole book. If my future is already written, if I will receive exactly what I was always going to receive, then why work hard? Why pray? Why lie awake hoping, if the ending is already on the page?

I used to think this was my question, or at least the question of a tired and anxious generation. It is not. It is one of the oldest

questions human beings ever wrote down. And more than two thousand years ago, someone gave an answer that I still think is one of the cleverest replies in the history of thought.

* * *

The ancient Greeks had a name for the argument. They called it the *lazy argument*, or the *idle argument*. The Roman writer Cicero preserved it in a short book called *On Fate*, written in the year Julius Caesar was murdered. His version is about illness, but it works for anything. Here it is, applied to an exam.

If it is fated that you will pass this exam, you will pass whether you study or not.

If it is fated that you will fail, you will fail whether you study or not.

One of the two is fated.

So studying is pointless.

Cicero pointed out that if anyone took this argument seriously, they would do nothing at all in life. Why plant seeds, if the harvest is fated? Why call a doctor, if recovery is fated? Why look both ways before crossing the road? The argument does not just make effort pointless. It makes every action pointless.

And yet, if you believe the future is fixed, it seems very hard to escape. Each step sounds reasonable. Where exactly does it go wrong?

* * *

The answer came from a philosopher named Chrysippus, who led the Stoic school in Athens in the third century before the common era. The Stoics believed in fate as firmly as anyone ever has. They thought the whole universe was a single chain of causes. So

they could not answer the lazy argument by saying fate does not exist. They had to find the mistake inside it.

Chrysippus found it. Some outcomes, he said, are *co-fated* with the actions that produce them. They are bound together like the two ends of the same rope.

It is not fated that you will pass the exam *whether or not you study*. If you are fated to pass, it may be fated that you will pass *by studying*. The result and the effort come as a package. Saying "I will pass whether or not I study" is like saying, in an example Cicero gives, that the great wrestler Milo will wrestle at the Olympic Games whether or not anyone wrestles against him. It is nonsense. The outcome contains the action inside it.

Read that slowly, because it changes everything.

The lazy argument imagines destiny as something that happens *to* us from the outside, a result that arrives regardless of what we do, like a parcel delivered to an empty house. Chrysippus imagines destiny as something that happens *through* us. If there is a written story, our choices are not outside it. They are among its sentences. If your destiny is written, your effort may be part of the ink.

* * *

Let me make this concrete, because there is a modern version of the same worry, and it sounds even more convincing than the ancient one.

Meet Nadia. She is a composite. She is nineteen, and in three weeks she has a final exam that will decide whether she can continue her degree. Tonight she is choosing between her notes and her phone.

Suppose she chooses the notes. Why did she choose them?

Trace it back. She studies because she is afraid of failing. She is afraid of failing because her parents sacrificed a great deal to send her to university, and she knows it. She has the discipline to sit down because her grandmother made her do her homework at the kitchen table every evening when she was eight. She has the energy tonight because she slept well, and she slept well because her flatmate was away. She can concentrate because of the brain she was born with, which she did not design.

Every link in that chain has a cause, and every cause has a cause behind it. Many scientists and philosophers believe this is true of every human choice: that each one is the product of what came before. Some go further and say there is no room left for anything we could call free will.

So here is the modern worry. If Nadia's decision to study was itself caused by things she did not choose, does her studying really matter? Isn't she just a domino falling in a line set up long before she was born?

* * *

Here is the answer, and I want to give it the room it deserves, because it is the single most useful idea in this part of the book.

A caused action can still be a cause.

Picture two versions of the same evening. In the first, Nadia studies for three hours. In the second, she spends the same three hours scrolling. Everything else is identical. Which Nadia walks into the exam better prepared? Obviously the first. Which is more likely to pass? The first.

That is all it means for an action to matter. To say Nadia's studying makes a difference is to say that, if she had not studied, things would probably have gone differently. That is true

whether or not her decision to study was itself caused by her grandmother, her fear and a good night's sleep. Her studying has causes behind it. It also has effects in front of it. Both are real at once.

Think of the dominoes again. Every domino in the line was pushed. It did not choose to fall. And every domino, as it falls, pushes the next one. Take one domino out of the line and the chain stops. The fact that it was pushed does not make it unimportant. It is exactly the piece that carries the push forward.

You are a domino that was pushed. You are also a domino that pushes.

This is why the oldest and newest versions of the worry fail in the same way. Whether the future is fixed by fate, by God or by the laws of physics, nothing in that idea says your effort is outside the chain. Your effort is one of the links. Remove it and the outcome changes. Keep it and the outcome changes too.

* * *

It helps to separate two ideas that people often mix up, because the mixing causes a great deal of needless despair.

The first idea is *fatalism*. In its everyday form, it says that certain outcomes will happen *no matter what you do*. The lazy argument is fatalism. So is the belief that you are "destined" to fail whatever you try, or that a particular person is "destined" to be yours whatever happens. Fatalism cuts the line between your actions and your outcomes.

The second idea is *determinism*: the view that everything that happens, including human choices, is the result of earlier causes.

They sound alike, but they point in opposite directions. Determinism does *not* say outcomes happen no matter what you

do. It says the opposite: that what you do is one of the causes of what happens. Nadia's studying is part of the chain that produces her exam result. Her studying has causes of its own, but it is still a cause.

Whether determinism is true, and whether it leaves room for free will, is a question philosophers are still arguing over, and we will look at the practical side of it in Chapter 10. But here is what matters now. Neither religious destiny nor scientific determinism supports the conclusion that effort is pointless. Only fatalism does. And fatalism, as the Stoics showed long ago, falls apart under careful thought.

* * *

There is a second answer to the lazy argument, and in practice I find it even more useful, because it does not depend on what you believe about fate at all.

Suppose everything really is written. Do you know what it says?

Nobody has ever read their destiny in advance. Not one person in history. We only read it backward, one page at a time, after the page has been lived. Before the event, the person who believes in destiny and the person who does not are standing in exactly the same place: in front of a choice, without knowing how it ends.

Destiny, then, can never tell you what to do *next*. It cannot tell Nadia whether to study tonight, because she does not know whether passing is written for her, or whether passing is written *together with* studying tonight. It cannot tell you whether to apply for the job, keep the shop open, start the treatment or make

the phone call. The only way to discover what was written is to live the page in front of you.

So the lazy argument fails twice. It fails in logic, because it forgets that outcomes can be bound up with the actions that bring them about. And it fails in practice, because even if it were sound, nobody could ever use it. We cannot consult the book. We can only write in it, or be written through it, whichever way you prefer to see it.

* * *

Then why does the lazy argument feel so convincing when we are hurting?

I think it is because destiny does two different jobs in our lives, and we confuse them.

The first job is comfort. When something we wanted is lost, the thought that it was "not meant to be" can bring real peace. It tells us we did not fail through carelessness. It lets us stop replaying the decision at three in the morning. For many people, the words *it was not written for me* are what finally let them sleep after a loss. I would never take those words from anyone.

The second job is guidance. Here destiny is asked to tell us what to do next: whether to try, whether to wait, whether to give up. And this is the job destiny cannot do, because we cannot read it in advance.

The trouble begins when we hand destiny the second job. Then it turns into waiting. *If the job is meant for me, it will come*, so we stop applying. *If my health is meant to recover, it will*, so we skip the appointment. *If she is meant for me, she will come back*, so we stop living and wait by the door. *If success is written, it will happen*, so we stop working, and are surprised when it does not.

I have watched people lose years this way. Not because they believed in destiny, but because they gave destiny the wrong job.

Destiny is a beautiful word for the past and a dangerous word for the future.

* * *

So here is how I have come to hold it, and I offer it whatever you believe.

When you look *backward*, at something already lived, use the language of destiny freely if it brings you peace. *It was not meant to be. It came at the right time.* These can be honest, healing words for a page that has already turned.

When you look *forward*, at the choice in front of you, set destiny gently aside. Not because it is false, but because it is silent. It does not tell you what to do. You must decide, with the best judgment you have, as though your choice matters, because whether you believe in fate, in God's knowledge, in physics or in none of these, it does. It is one of the ways the story gets written.

The archer does not know where her arrow will land. Perhaps somewhere it is already known. But she cannot read that place before she shoots. She can only draw, aim and release. And if the landing place is written, then her drawing and aiming are written too, as part of the same sentence.

There is no version of destiny in which the bow draws itself.

For your quiver

A caused action can still be a cause.

Practice. Take a sentence you have told yourself that uses destiny to stop you acting, such as "If it's meant to happen, it will happen" or "There's no point, it's already decided." Write it out as a full argument, step by step, like the lazy argument. Find the step that assumes your action cannot be part of what happens. Cross it out. What is left?

Chapter 9: Reading the page backward

In June 2005, Steve Jobs stood in front of the graduating class at Stanford University and told them three stories from his life. The first was about dropping out of college.

He had left Reed College after one semester, he said, because he could not see the point of spending his working-class parents' savings on courses he did not care about. But he stayed around the campus for another eighteen months, sleeping on friends' floors and sitting in on classes that interested him. One of them was calligraphy. He learned about typefaces, about the spaces between letters, about what makes beautiful printing beautiful. None of it had any practical use in his life.

Ten years later, when he and his colleagues were designing the first Macintosh computer, it all came back. The Mac, he said, became the first personal computer with beautiful typography, and if he had never wandered into that one class, it would not have.

Then he made the point that people have repeated ever since. You cannot join the dots of your life looking forward, he told the students. You can only join them looking back. So you have to trust that somehow they will connect in your future.

It is a lovely idea, and partly true. I want to look at it carefully, because inside it is the most important thing to understand about destiny as we actually feel it.

* * *

Notice what makes the calligraphy story work. It works because the Macintosh succeeded and Apple became one of the most famous companies on earth. Suppose instead that Jobs's first company had failed in its second year, as most new companies do. Would the calligraphy class still be a dot that connected? Almost certainly not. It would be a curious detail in the life of a man who dropped out of college, an interesting waste of time that nobody would think to mention.

The dots we connect, looking back, are the ones that lead to wherever we happen to be standing. They look like a path because we are at the end of it. If we had ended up somewhere else, a different set of dots would have lit up, and they would have looked like a path too.

That is not a criticism of Jobs. It is something every human being does. We are story-making creatures. When we look back over our lives, we cannot help seeing a shape, a direction, a sense that things were leading somewhere. And when the shape is strong enough, we give it a name. We call it destiny.

* * *

In the early 1970s, a young psychologist named Baruch Fischhoff ran a set of experiments that showed how powerfully knowing the ending changes the way we see the past.

In one of them, he gave people a short account of a historical conflict they knew nothing about: a war in the early nineteenth

century between the British and the Gurkhas of Nepal. He described the background and asked how likely various outcomes had been. Some participants were told nothing about how the war ended. Others were told the British had won. Others that the Gurkhas had won. Others that it ended in stalemate, or in a peace settlement.

Whatever ending people were told, they judged that ending to have been more likely. They looked at the same evidence and found in it the seeds of whatever outcome they believed had happened. And they did not realize that knowing the ending had changed their judgment. They believed they would have seen it coming anyway.

In another study, Fischhoff and his colleague Ruth Beyth asked people to predict the results of President Nixon's historic visits to China and the Soviet Union in 1972, before the trips took place. Afterward, they asked the same people to recall what they had predicted. People tended to remember giving higher odds to the things that actually happened and lower odds to the things that did not. Their memories had moved toward the truth, and they had not felt them move.

Fischhoff gave this tendency a name I find almost poetic. He called it *creeping determinism*. Once we know how something turned out, the past begins to look as though it could only have turned out that way. The feeling of inevitability creeps backward into moments that, at the time, were genuinely open.

The past looks inevitable only because you are standing at the end of it.

* * *

Why does this matter in a book about destiny?

Because much of what we feel as destiny is creeping determinism. It is the natural feeling that comes from looking at our lives from the end of the road. It does not prove the road was fixed. It does not prove it was open, either. It simply tells us that the human mind, looking back, draws paths.

People who believe in destiny for deep reasons, religious or philosophical, need not be troubled by this. Their belief does not rest on a feeling; it rests on their faith or their reasoning. But it helps to know that the *feeling* of "it was always going to happen" will arrive whether or not anything was ever written. It arrives for everyone, about everything, once the ending is known.

There is a word in Arabic, *maktub*, which means "it is written." It has traveled far beyond the Arabic-speaking world. People say it with a certain peace after something has happened. I love the word. But notice the tense. It is almost always said about the past.

* * *

This matters most when we look back at our failures.

When Sara replayed her final interview in the weeks after the rejection, it began to seem obvious that she had never really had a chance. Of course they chose Daniel. She had been too nervous. Her answer about teamwork was weak. She should have known from the manager's face. A month earlier, walking out of that same interview, she had been sure it had gone well. Nothing about the interview had changed. Only the ending had arrived and started rewriting the story backward.

The same thing happens to the founder whose business closes (*it was obviously a bad idea from the start*), to the patient whose treatment did not work (*I should have known*), to the couple

whose marriage ended (*the signs were always there*). Some of those judgments may be true. But many of them are creeping determinism wearing the clothes of wisdom. The signs look obvious only after you know which ones turned out to matter.

Be careful with the sentence *I should have known*. Very often, you could not have.

* * *

There is something else worth noticing: we do not use the language of destiny evenly.

Listen to how people talk about their lives and you will often hear a pattern. When something goes well, it was *meant to be*, or it was the reward of effort. When something goes badly, it was *bad luck*, or somebody else's fault. Psychologists call one version of this the *self-serving bias*: crediting our successes to ourselves and our failures to circumstances. It is very common, and in modest doses it probably helps us; it protects our confidence and keeps us trying.

But many people have the opposite pattern, and they are often exactly the people who pick up books like this one. When something goes well, it was luck. *I got lucky. Anyone could have done it.* When something goes badly, it was their fault. *I wasn't good enough. I should have known.* Success is luck; failure is character. This pattern is common in people who are anxious or depressed, and it is a recipe for misery, because nothing good ever counts and everything bad always does.

Both patterns have the same structure. They take events that were a mixture of effort, luck and things nobody could see, and sort them with different words depending on how they ended.

The words are doing something to us. They are turning uncertainty into rules about who we are.

So try a small, honest discipline. When you tell the story of something that happened to you, good or bad, include three things: what you did, what you did not control, and what you still do not know. Do it for your successes as carefully as for your failures.

I prepared hard for that interview, I was lucky that the manager had a problem I had solved before, and I don't know how close the other candidates were. That is a true story. It is also a sturdy one. It will not collapse the next time things go badly.

* * *

The psychologist Dan McAdams has spent decades studying the stories people tell about their own lives. He has found that people who tell what he calls *redemption* stories, in which something bad eventually leads to something good, tend on average to report greater well-being and to invest more in caring for others and for the next generation.

This is encouraging, and I believe it. How we tell our story matters. But there is a way of using this finding that does damage, and I want to warn you about it.

A redemption story cannot be forced. If you insist, in the first raw weeks after a loss, that this must be leading somewhere wonderful, you put a weight on yourself and on the future that neither can carry. You start searching every day for the hidden gift and feel like a failure when you cannot find it. Some losses do not get redeemed in any clear way. Sometimes the dots do not connect, or not for a very long time, or not into the picture you would have chosen.

The healthy form of a redemption story is not *this was secretly good*. It is closer to *this was bad, and I built something after it*. The meaning comes from what you do next, not from pretending the loss was a present.

* * *

So what is destiny, in the way most of us actually live it?

Whatever is or is not written into the deep structure of the universe, what we experience as destiny is a reading: the story we tell when we look back at the pages we have lived. It is a real story, and we cannot live without it. But it is always written after the fact, in the light of how things turned out, by a mind that naturally draws paths.

That has two consequences, and I want you to hold both.

The first is mercy toward your past self. When you look back at a failure and feel it was inevitable, remember creeping determinism. At the time, it was open. Your past self stood in front of a genuinely uncertain choice, exactly as you stand in front of one now. Be as fair to them as you would want someone to be to you.

The second is freedom toward your future. The page you are on has not been read yet. Whatever you believe about who or what holds the pen, you are where every human being has always been: in front of an open choice, with a story to live and no way to read the ending before you get there.

Jobs was right that you have to trust something. You do not have to trust that the dots will join into a beautiful picture. You can trust something smaller and sturdier: that what you do today will become one of the dots, and that you will be the one who decides, later, what it meant.

For your quiver

The past looks inevitable only because you are standing at the end of it.

Practice. Choose one important event in your life. Write it three times: once as a story of destiny, once as a story of luck and once as a story of effort. Then write it a fourth time, honestly including all three, plus one thing you still do not know. Read the four versions aloud. Which one would you want to believe on your worst day? Which one is true?

Chapter 10: The room you have to act

In the spring of 1870, a twenty-eight-year-old American named William James was in serious trouble.

He had trained as a doctor but did not want to practice. His health was poor. He was living in his parents' house in Cambridge, Massachusetts, unsure what to do with his life, and he had sunk into a depression so deep that, by his own later account, he had thought about ending it.

Part of what was crushing him was an idea. James had been studying science and philosophy, and he had come to find the case for determinism overwhelming. If every event was the product of earlier causes, then so was every human thought and every human choice. A person was a kind of machine, running out a program set in motion long before birth. And if that was true, what was the point of striving? His own will, which he desperately needed to climb out of his despair, seemed to him an illusion.

Then he read an essay by a French philosopher, Charles Renouvier, who described free will as the act of holding on to a thought because you choose to, when you could be thinking something else. James was struck by it. On the thirtieth of April, 1870, he wrote in his diary that the previous day had been a turn-

ing point in his life. He had decided, he wrote, that his first act of free will would be to believe in free will.

It was not an argument, and James knew it. He had not proved determinism false. He had simply decided to live as though his choices mattered, and to see what happened.

What happened was that he slowly recovered. Not overnight, and not completely; he struggled with low moods all his life. But he never sank so deep again. He went on to become one of the founders of modern psychology and one of the warmest, most readable philosophers America has produced.

* * *

I tell you this story not because it settles the question of free will. It does not. Philosophers and scientists are arguing about it more fiercely than ever.

Some argue that free will is an illusion. The neuroscientist Robert Sapolsky, in a book called *Determined*, published in 2023, makes the case that every human action is the product of biology and circumstance: genes, hormones, brain chemistry, childhood, culture and the events of the previous few seconds, all the way down. There is no self floating free of all that and choosing on its own.

Interestingly, Sapolsky does not conclude that we should stop trying. He concludes that we should become far more compassionate, toward others and toward ourselves, because nobody chose the forces that shaped them. The person who failed did not freely choose to fail. The person who succeeded did not freely choose to succeed either.

Many philosophers disagree with him. A large group, often called *compatibilists*, argue that the freedom that matters to us

was never about escaping causes. It is about acting on your own reasons and values without being forced or tricked. A woman who studies medicine because she cares about healing is acting freely in this sense, even though her caring has causes. A woman who studies medicine because her father will disown her if she does not is less free, even though both choices have causes.

We saw in Chapter 8 that a caused action can still be a cause, so the practical question in front of you stays the same whichever side is right: what should I do? And underneath it is a second question that, for most people, matters far more than the philosophy.

Not *am I free?* but *how much room do I have to act?*

* * *

Room is a better word than freedom for most of real life, because room comes in different sizes, and three things shape its size more than any others: money, time and obligations.

Imagine two people who both want to leave jobs they hate and retrain for a new career.

The first is single, has no children, has savings that would cover a year without income and has parents who would let her move home if things went badly. Her room is large. She can take a risk, because failure would be survivable.

The second has two young children, a mortgage, a mother who depends on her for daily care and no savings to speak of. Her room is much smaller. She has the same wish, and perhaps the same courage. But a choice that would be bold for the first woman could be reckless for her.

If we told both of them simply to *follow your dreams* or *take responsibility for your life*, we would be talking nonsense to one of

them. They do not have the same amount of room. Pretending they do is not inspiring. It is cruel.

* * *

Money does more than limit our options. It reaches inside our heads.

In 2013, a team of researchers including Sendhil Mullainathan and Eldar Shafir published a study of sugarcane farmers in India. These farmers are paid once a year, at harvest. In the months before harvest, money is tight; just after harvest, it is plentiful. The researchers gave the same farmers a set of mental tests at both times. The farmers performed noticeably worse before the harvest, when they were short of money, than after it, when they were not. They were the same people with the same intelligence. The difference was the weight of their worries.

The researchers' explanation was that scarcity takes up mental space. When you are worried about rent, school fees or the next meal, part of your mind is always busy with that worry, and less of it is free for planning, learning and choosing well. Time pressure and heavy caring duties seem to work in a similar way. A person juggling three jobs and a sick parent is not only short of hours. She is short of the calm attention that good decisions require.

This matters enormously when we judge ourselves, or others, for "not trying hard enough." Sometimes what looks like a lack of effort is a lack of room. The bow is being drawn in a very small space, with very little air.

* * *

But notice that the second woman is not without room. Hers is smaller, and its shape is different. Perhaps she can take a course in the evenings. Perhaps she can save slowly for two years. Perhaps she can find a role that bridges her old career and the new one. Perhaps she can ask for help she has been too proud to ask for. Her choices are real. They are harder, and they will take longer.

Taking responsibility begins with an honest account of the room you have to act.

It helps, when the room feels small, to name exactly what is making it small. Constraints are far less overwhelming when they are named one by one than when they are felt all at once as a fog of impossibility.

Some constraints are *outside you and fixed*, at least for now: a law, an illness, a family duty you will not abandon, the state of the economy.

Some are *outside you but negotiable*: an employer who might agree to flexible hours, relatives who might share a responsibility, a bank that might reschedule a loan, a deadline that might move if you ask.

Some are *inside you*: habits, fears, beliefs about what people like you are allowed to do, an old story about your own limits. These are often the hardest to see and, sometimes, the most possible to change.

And some are simply *missing information*. You do not know whether something is possible because you have never asked.

When you sort your constraints this way, the room usually turns out larger than it felt. Never unlimited. But a person who believes they have no room at all is often looking at a mixture of real walls and painted ones, and cannot tell them apart in the dark.

* * *

The psychiatrist Viktor Frankl survived the Nazi concentration camps and wrote about them in a short book called *Man's Search for Meaning*. One of his central observations was that even there, when everything else had been taken, a person kept one last freedom: the freedom to choose the attitude he would take toward his circumstances.

That idea is often misused, so I want to handle it carefully. Frankl was not saying that attitude is all that matters, or that suffering people just need a better outlook. He was a prisoner in a place built to strip human beings of every other kind of room. He survived partly by chance, and he knew it. His point was that even in the smallest room any human being has ever been forced into, some room remained. Not enough to save himself. Enough to remain himself.

If that was true in the camps, it is true in your situation too. Your room may be small. It is almost never zero.

* * *

Here is the most hopeful thing in this chapter. Room is not fixed. You can make it larger.

Every month of savings is room. Every new skill is room. Every person who knows and trusts you is room. Every year of good health is room. Every piece of information about your options is room. None of these guarantee anything. Each one gives your future self more choices, more ways to respond when the wind changes, more doors to try when one closes.

This is one of the most practical answers I know to the questions that began this book. If you cannot control the outcome, cannot read your destiny and cannot be sure your choices are

free in the deepest philosophical sense, what *can* you do? You can widen your room, so that whatever happens, you will have more ways to meet it.

The archer did not choose her height, the length of her arms, the first bow she was handed or the wind on the day of the contest. Those were given. Within them she chose where to stand, how to train, which arrows to carry and, finally, where to aim. And over the years, by those choices, she made her own room larger: a stronger draw, a steadier hand, a better eye for the wind.

William James could not prove he was free. He decided to act as though his room was real, and then spent his life making it larger. That is as good an answer to the question as anyone has found.

For your quiver

Your room may be small. It is almost never zero.

Practice. Think of a choice you feel stuck on. List every constraint you can think of, then sort each one into four groups: outside me and fixed, outside me but negotiable, inside me, and missing information. Pick one item from the negotiable or missing-information groups and take one step on it this week: ask the question, have the conversation, look up the answer.

Part Four: The breath

On hope: when the future you imagined disappears, how to find another road, and how to live through the wait

Hope is the breath you take before an action whose ending you cannot see.

Chapter 11: When the future you imagined disappears

Some losses take something you have. The ones that keep you awake take something you were about to have.

A young woman fails her medical licensing exam for the third and final time. On paper she has lost an exam. In her own mind she has lost a doctor. For six years she has been that doctor in private, in the shower and on the bus: the white coat, the first patient, the way her grandmother would say the title out loud at family dinners. The exam board has no idea it has just cancelled a person.

A man's visa is refused after three years of waiting. He had already chosen the neighborhood. He knew which bus he would take to work, what the winter would feel like, how he would describe the first snow on the phone to his mother. A one-page letter has removed a city he had been living in for years without ever arriving.

A footballer tears a knee ligament at nineteen. A couple are told the last round of fertility treatment has not worked. A founder signs the papers that close the company she spent seven years building. A family sells the farm that four generations

worked. Someone is told, gently, that the wedding will not happen.

In each case there is a visible event: a result, a letter, a diagnosis, a conversation. And in each case, something much larger and almost invisible disappears with it. A future the person had already begun to live in.

This chapter is about that second loss. It comes first in the part of the book about hope, because you cannot build a new hope on top of a grief you have not acknowledged. Before you look for another road, you have to stand for a while at the place where the old one ended.

* * *

Why does losing something that never existed hurt so much?

Because in a sense it did exist. Not in the world, but in us.

In 1986, the psychologists Hazel Markus and Paula Nurius published a paper on what they called *possible selves*. We all carry pictures of who we might become: the selves we hope for, and the selves we fear. The successful lawyer. The good father. The person who finally lives abroad. The person who ends up alone. These pictures are not idle daydreams. They steer us. They decide which classes we take, which risks we run, which mornings we get up early. A hoped-for self is a kind of compass, and we spend years walking by it.

So when a hoped-for future closes, we lose more than an outcome. We lose the compass we had been walking by. That is why people so often say, after a loss like this, *I don't know who I am anymore.* They are not being dramatic. They are describing exactly what happened.

It helps to see the separate layers of what goes missing, because each one needs its own kind of grief.

There is *identity*: the person you were becoming. The doctor, the athlete, the founder, the wife, the one who made it.

There is *daily life*: the ordinary days you had pictured. The commute, the office, the house, the kitchen in the new city, the routine with the child.

There are *relationships*: the people who would have filled that life. Colleagues, teammates, a partner, a community, sometimes one particular person.

There is *the story you told others*: the announcement you had half-written, the relatives who kept asking, the friends who already called you by the new title.

And there is *meaning*: the sense that your effort was leading somewhere, that the sacrifices added up to something.

When you lose an imagined future, you can lose all five at once. It is no wonder it feels like more than one loss. It is more than one loss.

* * *

There is a further cruelty, and it is the silence.

When someone dies, the world knows what to do. There are rituals, prayers, flowers, food brought to the door, time off work, people who sit with you. The grief is recognized.

When a future dies, there is usually nothing. No funeral. No days off. No one brings food because you failed the exam for the last time or because the visa was refused. If you mention it, people often hurry to fix it. *You're young, there will be other chances. At least you have your health. It wasn't meant to be. Everything happens for a reason.* They mean well. But each of these sen-

tences tells you, gently, that your grief is too big for what happened, and that you should put it away.

The grief researcher Kenneth Doka gave this a name in 1989: *disenfranchised grief*. It is grief that is not openly acknowledged, not publicly mourned and not socially supported. The family therapist Pauline Boss described a related experience she called *ambiguous loss*: a loss without clear edges or closure, where the world does not quite agree that anything has been lost at all.

There is no funeral for a future that never arrived. And because there is no funeral, many people never let themselves mourn it. They carry it unopened for years.

* * *

So the first thing I want to say to you, if you are standing where an imagined future used to be, is simply this: what you are feeling is grief, and it deserves to be treated as grief.

You are allowed to be sad for longer than other people think is reasonable. You are allowed to feel angry, at the examiners, at the employer, at your body, at the person who left, at yourself, at God, at nobody in particular. You are allowed to feel confused, because your compass has gone and you are not yet sure which way is forward. None of this means you are weak or ungrateful or faithless. It means you loved a future, and it is gone.

You also do not have to rush to find the meaning in it. In Chapter 9 we saw that redemption stories can help, but only when they grow naturally. A loss forced into a lesson too early becomes a second burden. You do not have to call this a gift. You may never call it a gift. You can still build a good life after it.

And it helps to know that accepting what happened is not the same as agreeing that it was fair. Acceptance only means you stop

arguing with the fact that it happened. It does not mean you approve of it, or that you think you deserved it, or that you have stopped wishing it had gone differently. You can accept a closed door and still believe it should have opened.

* * *

There is some encouraging research on what happens to people who face their lost futures honestly.

In 2007, the psychologists Laura King and Joshua Hicks reviewed a series of studies on what they called *lost possible selves*: the people we once hoped to become and now never will. They found something that at first seems contradictory. Spending time thinking about a lost possible self was linked to more regret and lower happiness in the moment. It hurts to look. But people who were able to describe their lost selves fully and honestly, in rich detail rather than brushing them aside, tended over time to show more personal maturity: a more complex, more compassionate, more grounded way of understanding themselves and the world.

In other words, looking straight at what you lost costs you some comfort now and gives you something deeper later. The people who grow are not the ones who never grieve. They are the ones who grieve with their eyes open.

There is also a simple practice with a long history behind it. In the 1980s, the psychologist James Pennebaker began asking people to spend fifteen or twenty minutes a day, for a few days, writing about their deepest thoughts and feelings about a painful experience. Across many studies since, people who did this kind of writing have often reported benefits, including, in his early work, fewer visits to the doctor in the months that followed. The effects vary and are usually modest. But the method is free, pri-

vate and available tonight, and the exercise at the end of this chapter is built on it.

* * *

When Sara finally sat down, about a month after her rejection, and let herself look at what she had lost, she was surprised by how much was there.

She had lost a job, of course. But she had also lost a version of herself: the young woman with the lanyard from the famous company, the one her relatives would mention to other relatives. She had lost a daily life: the bus to the glass building, lunch with clever colleagues, a desk with a view. She had lost the phone call to her father that she had rehearsed in her head a hundred times. She had lost the story she was going to tell at her cousin's wedding. And she had lost, for a while, the feeling that her two years of effort had been leading somewhere.

Writing it all down did not make it hurt less that evening. It made it hurt more. But the next morning, something had shifted. The loss was no longer a fog. It had edges. She could see what she was actually grieving, and she could see that some of it, like the respect, the learning, the help she wanted to give her family, did not live only in that one building. That discovery belongs to the next chapter. It could not have come before this one.

* * *

The last thing I want to say here is about support, because people who lose imagined futures tend to grieve alone.

When you tell someone what happened, try telling them the full size of the loss, not just the event. Not *I failed the exam*, but *I've been a doctor in my head for six years, and today she died.*

Not *the visa was refused*, but *I've been living in that city for three years and I just found out I'll never arrive.* Most people respond very differently when they understand what was really lost. You give them the chance to sit with you instead of trying to fix you.

And if the grief does not ease with time, if weeks become months and you cannot eat or sleep or get out of bed, please speak to a doctor or a counselor. Some losses are heavier than one person should carry alone. Asking for help with them is not a failure of hope. It is an act of it.

The archer who has just watched her arrow fall far from the target does not need, in that moment, a lecture on technique. She needs to stand still for a while, feel what she feels, and let someone stand beside her. The next arrow can wait until her hands stop shaking.

For your quiver

There is no funeral for a future that never arrived. Hold one anyway.

Practice. Set aside twenty minutes and write four short sections about a future you have lost. What happened: the plain facts. What was lost: go through identity, daily life, relationships, the story you told others and meaning, and write what disappeared in each. What is unknown: the questions that remain unanswered, without forcing answers. What support would help now: one person you could tell the full size of this loss, and what you would like from them.

Chapter 12: The thing with feathers

The oldest story about hope I know is also one of the strangest.

The Greek poet Hesiod, writing around seven hundred years before the common era, tells how the god Zeus, angry with humankind, created the first woman, Pandora, and sent her to earth with a large storage jar. (Centuries later, a translator turned the jar into a "box," and the box is how most of us know the story.) Inside were all the evils that would trouble human life: sickness, toil, sorrow and the rest. Until then, people had lived without them.

Pandora lifted the lid. The evils flew out and scattered across the world, where they have been ever since. In terror, she slammed the lid back down. One thing was left inside, caught under the rim, unable to escape.

It was hope.

For nearly three thousand years, people have argued about what this means. Why was hope in a jar full of evils? Was it kept inside so that it would stay with us, the one consolation we kept? Or was hope itself one of the evils, the cruelest of them all?

The German philosopher Friedrich Nietzsche chose the darkest reading. Zeus, he argued, did not want people to throw away their lives, however much the other evils tormented them. He

wanted them to keep enduring the torment. So he gave them hope, which keeps human suffering going longer than it otherwise would, and is therefore the worst evil of all.

When I first read that, I wanted to argue. Then I thought of the people I know who spent years waiting for something that was never going to come, and I was less sure.

* * *

About seventeen years before Nietzsche wrote those words, in a small town in Massachusetts, a woman who rarely left her family's house wrote a poem that gives the opposite answer. Emily Dickinson published almost nothing in her lifetime; her poems were gathered and printed only after her death. In one of them she pictures hope as a small bird with feathers that lives inside the soul. It sings a song without words. It never stops singing, not even in the fiercest storm, in the coldest land, on the strangest sea. And in the poem's last lines she notices something remarkable about this bird: in all its years of singing through her worst moments, it never once asked her for even a crumb.

For Dickinson, hope is not a torment. It is a gift that asks for nothing. It keeps singing whether or not the singing changes anything, and keeps a person company in the dark.

So who is right? Is hope the last evil in the jar, or the bird that sings in the storm?

I have come to believe they are both right, because they are describing two different things that share one name. The rest of this chapter is about telling them apart, and about growing the kind that helps.

* * *

The first thing to understand is that hope is not optimism, though we often use the words as if they were twins.

In 2005, the psychologists Patricia Bruininks and Bertram Malle asked people to describe what they meant by hope, optimism, wishing and related states, and to write about times they had felt each one. A clear pattern emerged. Optimism was about outcomes people expected to go well. Hope was about outcomes that mattered more to them, that were less likely, and that were less under their own control. People were optimistic about things that seemed probable. They hoped for things that were important and uncertain.

That small finding explains a great deal. Hope lives exactly where this whole book lives: at the edge of our control, where effort meets the wind. You do not need hope to switch on a light. You need it to apply for the job, start the treatment, wait for the result, ask the question, plant the field. Optimism is a forecast. Hope is a decision to keep moving toward something you cannot be sure of.

Which means that hope is not a soft feeling for people who cannot face facts. It is the particular courage required to act when facts run out.

* * *

In the 1980s and 1990s, a psychologist at the University of Kansas named Charles Richard Snyder set out to study hope scientifically. Until then, most psychologists treated it as a vague, warm mood. Snyder argued that real hope is more specific and more practical, and that it has two parts.

The first he called *agency*. It is the sense that you can get yourself moving toward a goal and keep going. Snyder sometimes

called it willpower: the inner voice that says, *I can start, and I can keep at it.*

The second he called *pathways*. It is the ability to see routes to your goal, and, most important, to find new routes when the first one is blocked. Snyder sometimes called it waypower: the inner voice that says, *Here is one way. And if that does not work, here is another.*

Snyder and his colleagues built a short questionnaire to measure these two parts, and over the following decades researchers used it in hundreds of studies. People who scored higher on hope tended to set clearer goals, think of more ways to reach them and keep going longer when they hit obstacles. Higher hope has been linked, in many of these studies, with better results in school and sport and with better coping during illness.

What I find most useful is the second part. High-hope people are not simply people who feel sure things will work out. They are people who can see more than one road. When one closes, they do not conclude that the destination is lost. They start looking for another way there.

That is the job of this chapter. In the last chapter we stood at the place where a road ended. Now we look for others.

* * *

The psychologist Gabriele Oettingen, working first in Germany and later in New York, discovered something about hope that surprised even her, and that everyone who dreams about anything should know.

In one study, published with Doris Mayer in 2002, she asked university students who were about to graduate how often they

fantasized about getting their dream job, and how positive those fantasies were. Then she followed them for two years.

You might expect the students with the most vivid, glowing fantasies to have done best. They were the most hopeful, surely. The opposite happened. Two years later, the graduates who had indulged most in positive fantasies had received fewer job offers and were earning lower salaries than those whose thoughts about the future had been more mixed. Oettingen found similar patterns elsewhere: among patients hoping to recover well from hip surgery, and among students hoping that a crush would turn into a relationship.

Her explanation is that a vivid positive fantasy lets the mind taste the reward in advance. It feels wonderful. And because it feels as if we have already arrived, it drains away some of the energy we need to make the actual trip.

Oettingen did not conclude that we should stop dreaming. She found that a dream becomes powerful when it is joined to an honest look at the obstacle. She called this *mental contrasting*: first imagine the wish and its best outcome as vividly as you can, then imagine, just as vividly, the main thing inside you or around you that stands in the way. When people did this, those with a realistic chance of success became more energized and more likely to act. She later combined it with a simple if-then plan, *if this obstacle appears, then I will do that*, into a method she calls WOOP: Wish, Outcome, Obstacle, Plan.

I should be honest about the size of the effect. A review published in 2021 found that combining mental contrasting with if-then plans helps people reach their goals on average, but the effect is small to moderate, and some published studies may have overstated it. It is a useful tool, not a magic one. But the insight underneath matches what I have seen in life. The people who

dream best are not the people who dream most. They are the people whose dream can look the obstacle in the eye.

Fantasy rehearses the arrival. Hope rehearses the road.

* * *

There is one more voice I want to bring into this conversation, because it reaches the deepest layer of hope.

Václav Havel was a Czech playwright who spent years opposing the communist government of his country. He was watched, harassed and imprisoned. His plays were banned. The regime looked permanent, and he had every reason to believe that nothing he did would change anything. In a long series of conversations recorded in the mid-1980s, later published as *Disturbing the Peace*, he was asked whether he still had hope.

His answer has been repeated around the world ever since. Hope, he said, is not the same as optimism. It is not a conviction that things will turn out well. It is a certainty that what you are doing makes sense, however it turns out.

A few years later, in 1989, the regime fell, almost without bloodshed, and Havel became president of his country. But notice that his hope never depended on that. He was not hoping because he predicted the government's collapse. He was hoping because he believed that living truthfully was worth doing whether the government fell or not.

This is hope that the outcome cannot break, because it was never staked on the outcome. It is staked on meaning. And it is the kind the archer needs most. She hopes to hit the target, of course. But beneath that hope lies a deeper one: that drawing the bow well is worth doing, that the practice and the aim and the

courage to let go make sense, whether this particular arrow lands or not.

* * *

For many people, hope has an older and more serious form, and its name is prayer.

I will not tell you what happens on the other side of a prayer. That is a question of faith, and people answer it differently. But anyone, believer or not, can see what prayer does on this side, in the life of the person who prays, and it is remarkably close to everything this chapter has described.

Prayer names what you want, and in naming it, you often discover what you really want. A person who prays every night for "the job" may find one night that the words have changed into a prayer for security, or dignity, or a chance to use their gifts. That discovery opens new roads to the same place.

Prayer marks the edge of your power. Nobody prays to be able to lift their own hand. We pray about the things we cannot fully control: the decision on the other side of the desk, the result of the scan, the heart of another person. It draws the line, honestly, between the bow and the wind.

And in every tradition I know of, prayer was never meant to replace effort. The people most respected for their prayers were also respected for their work. You breathe in. Then you draw the bow.

One more thing, because so many people carry this wound. An unanswered prayer is not a verdict on the one who prayed. On the morning of Sara's interview, her mother prayed for her. On the same morning, Daniel's grandmother prayed for him. Both prayers were sincere. Both came from love. There was one job.

Whatever you believe about how prayer works, a world where many people want the same scarce things cannot grant every sincere prayer in the form it was asked. A *no* is not proof that you were not loved, or not sincere enough, or not good enough.

* * *

Now we can see what Nietzsche and Dickinson were each describing.

Nietzsche's hope is the one that becomes a substitute for action and a refusal to look at reality. It is the fantasy that keeps a person waiting at a door that has closed, rehearsing a reunion that will never come, refusing every other possibility because *this* one must come true. That kind of hope really can prolong suffering. It is a bird that sings so sweetly you never leave the cage.

Dickinson's hope is something else. It does not demand a particular outcome. It asks for no crumb. It is a basic turning of the soul toward life, a refusal to let the dark have the last word, even when you cannot see what morning will bring.

So here is a working picture of healthy hope.

It has a *direction*: something you value, something worth moving toward. That is Havel's hope, and Dickinson's bird.

It has *roads*: a concrete next step, and more than one route. That is Snyder's pathways.

It looks at the *obstacle* honestly. That is Oettingen's contrast.

And it never makes a single outcome the condition of its own survival.

Give your hope more than one road to travel.

* * *

When Sara was preparing for her interview, she sometimes let herself imagine her first day: the lanyard, the call to her father. That was natural, and I would not take the pleasure from her. But the parts of her preparation that actually changed her odds were not the fantasies. They were the moments when she looked straight at the obstacle. *I freeze when they ask about failures. So I will practice that answer until I don't.* That was hope rehearsing the road.

After the rejection, once she had grieved, her hope had to change shape. It could no longer be a hope for that particular glass building. But when she asked what the building had stood for in her imagination, she found three things underneath it: the security of a good salary, the respect that comes from doing serious work, and the chance to learn fast from talented people. None of these lived only inside one company.

She wrote the three words on a card and stuck it above her desk. Then she wrote, underneath, three different roads that could lead to them. It took her ten minutes. It was the first time in weeks she had felt the bird begin to sing.

For your quiver

Give your hope more than one road to travel.

Practice. Write down one thing you are hoping for. Underneath it, write what this hope is really about, the value beneath the outcome. Then write the main obstacle, inside you or around you, as honestly as you can, and one if-then plan: "If this obstacle appears, then I will…" Finally, list three different roads that could lead toward the value, even if they do not lead to the original outcome.

Chapter 13: The optimists who did not come home

In September 1965, an American navy pilot named James Stockdale was shot down over North Vietnam. He ejected, landed in a village, was beaten by the people who found him and was taken to a prison in Hanoi that the American prisoners would later call, with bitter humor, the Hanoi Hilton.

He stayed there for more than seven years.

As the most senior navy officer among the prisoners, Stockdale became one of their leaders. He was tortured many times. He spent long stretches in solitary confinement, sometimes in leg irons. He had no rights, no release date and no way of knowing whether he would ever see his wife and sons again. He did not know whether the war would end in one year or ten.

Stockdale was released in 1973. Decades later, the business writer Jim Collins interviewed him for a book about why some companies become great, and asked a simple question. Who didn't make it out?

Stockdale's answer surprised him. The optimists, he said.

The optimists, as Stockdale described them, were the men who were sure they would be home by Christmas. Christmas came and went. Then they were sure they would be home by

Easter. Easter came and went. Then the next holiday, and then Christmas again. And in the end, Stockdale said, they died of a broken heart.

Then he described what he had done differently, and Collins later named it the *Stockdale Paradox*. Stockdale never lost faith that he would get out, and even that he would one day turn the experience into the defining event of his life. But he kept that faith completely separate from his reading of the present. He refused to lie to himself about how bad things were, or how long they might last. Faith in the ending. Brutal honesty about today. He insisted that you needed both, and that confusing them could kill you.

* * *

I want to be careful with this story, as I have tried to be careful with every story in this book. Stockdale was describing his memories of a terrible place, many years later. He was not running a study. We cannot know exactly why particular men did not survive; illness, injury, torture and despair were all bound up together. One man's observation is not a law of nature.

But Stockdale was not the only person to see this pattern.

Twenty years before Stockdale was shot down, the Austrian psychiatrist Viktor Frankl was a prisoner in the Nazi concentration camps. In *Man's Search for Meaning*, written soon after his liberation, he records something the chief doctor of his camp told him. In the week between Christmas 1944 and New Year 1945, the death rate in the camp rose beyond anything they had seen before. The work had not become harder. The food had not become worse. The weather had not changed in any special way. The doctor's explanation was that many prisoners had lived in the

hope of being home by Christmas. As the day came closer with no encouraging news, they lost courage, and the disappointment overwhelmed them.

Frankl also tells of a fellow prisoner who confided in him, in February 1945, that he had had a strange dream. A voice had offered to answer any question, and he had asked when the war would end for him. The voice had named a date: the thirtieth of March.

The man was full of hope. But as the thirtieth of March approached, the news from the front showed no sign of liberation. On the twenty-ninth, he fell suddenly ill with a high fever. On the thirtieth, the promised day, he lost consciousness. On the thirty-first of March, he died.

Frankl was a doctor, and he did not pretend that disappointment alone had killed his friend. The man died of typhus, which was everywhere in the camps. But Frankl believed, from long observation, that the collapse of a hope tied to a date had weakened his body's ability to fight.

* * *

Two men, in two wars, in two of the worst places human beings have ever built, saw the same thing. I do not think that is a coincidence. And I think it has something to teach those of us whose struggles are, thankfully, much smaller.

What failed, in both stories, was not hope. It was hope with a date.

The prisoners who said *we'll be out by Christmas* were not wrong to want freedom. They were not wrong to believe it would come; for many of them, eventually, it did. Their mistake, if such a word can even be used in a place of such suffering, was to tie

their hope to a specific outcome at a specific time. They made an appointment with the future, and the future did not keep it.

A hope with a date is not broken once. It is broken again every time the next date passes. Each disappointment takes something that is hard to replace. Eventually there is nothing left to hope with.

Hope that sets a date with the universe will one day be stood up.

* * *

What survived?

Stockdale held two things at once. The first was faith in the end of the story, an outcome so broad and so distant that no single Christmas could break it. Not *I will be home by Easter*, but *I will get out, and I will make something of this*. The second was ruthless honesty about the present. He looked at the facts every day and built his life around them. He helped organize ways for the prisoners to communicate secretly, tapping coded messages through the walls. He helped draw up rules for how the men should resist, so that no prisoner had to work out alone what was expected of him. He kept people connected, and connection kept them alive.

Frankl described something similar in his own camp, in different words. The prisoners who held up best were often those who had something to live *for*: a person waiting for them, a task unfinished, a book they intended to write. A reason to live can carry a person through almost any way of living. It was not a date. It was a meaning, and a meaning cannot be cancelled by a calendar.

* * *

Most of us will never be prisoners of war. But almost all of us will spend some part of our lives in a long wait, and waiting is its own kind of hard.

Waiting for a job after months of applications. Waiting for a visa, or a residence permit, or a court decision. Waiting for test results, and then for the treatment to work. Waiting, month after month, for a pregnancy. Waiting for a business to turn a profit. Waiting for a loan to be paid off. Waiting for a family to accept a marriage, or a child to come home, or a parent to forgive.

In these waits it is very natural to do what the optimists did. *By the end of the month I'll hear back. By summer I'll be well. By her birthday he'll have changed his mind. By next year everything will be different.* We set dates because dates give the fog a shape. They make the waiting feel finite.

There is nothing wrong with planning by dates. A target date for your own actions is a useful tool: *I will send ten applications by Friday. I will review my approach at the end of March. I will ask the clinic about other options after this cycle.* Those are promises you can keep.

The danger begins when the date becomes a prophecy about something you do not control. *I will have a job by March. He will come back by Eid. I will be cured by summer. The visa will come before the baby is born.* These are not plans. They are appointments with the wind. And when the wind does not show up, the hope tied to the appointment takes the blow.

A deadline is a tool. A prophecy is a trap.

* * *

So how do you hold hope through a long wait without letting it break you? Here is what I have learned from Stockdale, from

Frankl and from watching people I love live through their own long seasons.

Hope for the end of the story, not for a particular page. I will work again. I will build a life I am glad to live. I will find people to love who love me back. Hopes this wide cannot be killed by one disappointment.

Put your dates on your actions, never on outcomes. You decide when you apply, call, rest, review and try again. You do not decide when the answer comes.

Face the facts on a schedule. Once a week, perhaps, ask honestly: What is actually true right now? What has changed, and what has not? Facing reality on purpose, at a set time, is far less frightening than letting it ambush you at three in the morning.

Build meaning inside the wait, not only beyond it. Stockdale's men tapped messages through the walls. Frankl, sick in the camp, began rebuilding on scraps of paper the manuscript that had been taken from him. The wait is not an empty corridor between your old life and your real life. It is your life, right now. What can you learn, give or build inside it?

Do not wait alone. The tapping through the walls was not a small detail. Isolation turns waiting into despair faster than anything else. Find the people who will tap back.

* * *

There is a strange gift hidden in Stockdale's paradox, and I want to end with it.

When you stop tying your hope to a date, the hope becomes harder to break. That much is obvious. But something else happens too. You become free to notice the present: the small kindnesses, the unexpected openings, the people tapping through the

walls. The optimists in Stockdale's prison spent so much attention on the next Christmas that they had little left for the cell they were actually in. Stockdale, by accepting the cell, could work inside it.

The archer does not know when the wind will drop. If she decides it must drop by noon, and it does not, she may put down her bow in despair. But if she simply knows that winds change, that they always change eventually, she can keep the bow strung and her eyes open, and draw the moment the air goes still.

Faith in the ending. Honesty about today. That is the kind of hope that brings people home.

For your quiver

Hope that sets a date with the universe will one day be stood up.

Practice. Write down any hope you are holding that has a date attached to an outcome you do not control. Rewrite each one in two parts: a wide hope for the end of the story, and a dated plan for your own next actions. Then choose one day each week when you will look at the facts on purpose, and put it in your calendar.

Part Five: The archer

On living with all four: when a door stays shut, when the future needs someone else's yes, when to keep going and when to aim somewhere new

The arrow will land where it lands. What happens next belongs to the archer.

Chapter 14: The door that did not open

Rejection comes in many envelopes.

A university writes to say it received many outstanding applications this year. A publisher returns the manuscript with a printed note. An investor listens to the whole pitch, nods warmly and never replies. A casting director says *thank you, next* before you reach the second verse. A scholarship committee announces its winners, and your name is not among them. An embassy stamps a refusal in a passport. A company sends an automated message that does not even use your name.

Each of these is a different door. But the moment they close feels the same. A small, hard silence. Then the mind starts talking.

Three weeks after her first rejection, Sara applied for two more positions. One sent a refusal within forty-eight hours. The other never answered at all. There is a particular loneliness to this kind of season. It happens mostly in silence, at a screen, late at night. Each rejection is small enough that you feel you should not be so upset about it, and yet they pile up inside you like stones in a pocket. Other people do not see them. Often you do not tell anyone, because you are embarrassed, and because there is nothing anyone can do.

In many families, these doors carry more than one person's hopes. A university place, a job, a visa can be tied to money, status, marriage prospects, a parent's pride and sacrifices made years ago so that you could stand in front of that door. When it stays shut, people do not only feel that they failed. They feel, without anyone saying it, that they let everyone down.

If you are in a season like this, I want this chapter to sit beside you for a while. Not to cheer you up, but to help you think clearly at a time when clear thinking is hard.

* * *

Let me start with some good news, and it is real news from careful research.

In 1998, the psychologists Daniel Gilbert, Timothy Wilson and their colleagues published a set of studies on how well people predict their own feelings after bad events. They looked at a range of disappointments: the end of a romantic relationship, seeing a favored candidate lose an election, receiving negative feedback about one's personality, young professors waiting to hear whether they would receive tenure, the permanent post most academics spend years working toward, and people being turned down for a job they wanted.

The same pattern appeared again and again. People predicted that the bad event would make them miserable, and that the misery would last a long time. When the event actually happened, they felt bad, but less bad than they had predicted, and for less time. The professors who were denied tenure had expected to be unhappy for years. Some years later, they were reporting happiness not far from that of colleagues who had been promoted.

Gilbert and Wilson's explanation is that we all have a *psychological immune system*: a set of mental processes that help us recover from pain, find new meaning, notice new possibilities and make peace with what happened. Like the body's immune system, it works in the background. And because we rarely see it working, we forget it is there. So when we imagine a future disappointment, we imagine the pain and forget to imagine the recovery.

This does not mean rejection does not hurt. It does, and the first days can be very hard. But it does mean that the voice saying *I will never get over this* is, on the evidence, probably wrong. You are usually stronger than your forecast.

* * *

The second thing I want to say is about what a rejection actually tells you.

When a door closes, the mind wants a reason. Not knowing is almost unbearable, so the mind supplies one, and it usually supplies the most painful one available: *I wasn't good enough.*

But think of all the reasons a door might stay shut.

There may have been a real gap in your skills or experience. Your application may have been weaker than it could have been, even though you are well qualified. There may have been stronger candidates, or equally strong ones, and someone had to be chosen. There may have been an internal candidate the organization always meant to pick. The budget may have changed. The program may have been full before it opened. The person deciding may have had a bad day, a private preference or a bias, conscious or not. There may have been a quota, a policy, a dead-

line you did not know about. And there are almost always reasons you will never learn.

Of all these possibilities, only the first two are really about you, and even those are about your application and your current skills, not your worth as a person.

So when the mind supplies its verdict, supply the whole list instead. Not to excuse yourself, and not to blame the people on the other side, but to restore the truth. A rejection is a closed door, not a map of the building.

* * *

There is real value in finding out which reasons applied, when you can. This is where effort comes back in, in its most useful form.

Some organizations will give feedback if you ask. Many will not, often for legal reasons, and some will not reply at all. But it costs little to ask, politely and specifically. A good question is a narrow one: *Is there one thing that would have made my application stronger?* People find it much easier to answer one clear question than a vague request for feedback.

You can also find feedback elsewhere. A friend in the field. A former teacher or manager. Someone who has made these decisions themselves. Show them your application, your portfolio, your pitch. Rehearse with them, and ask them to be honest, even unkind.

When feedback comes, it will sometimes sting. Let it. Feedback is information about your approach. It is not information about your value. The danger in a long season of rejection is that the two get confused, so that each closed door lowers not your estimate of your application, but your estimate of yourself.

Let feedback change your approach before rejection changes your opinion of your worth.

And sometimes, after you have asked everyone you can, you still will not know why. That is the hardest outcome, and a very common one. Here is a rule that has helped me: *do not invent an explanation for what remains unknown.* Improve what you can see. Let the rest stay a question mark. A question mark is far lighter to carry than a false verdict.

* * *

What about the search itself? Here the lessons of earlier chapters become practical.

Remember the woodcutter. If you have sent out fifty applications in the same form and received nothing, the next step is not fifty more of the same. Stop, sharpen the axe, change something and go again.

Remember the weak ties. Many opportunities travel through people, and especially through acquaintances. Applying through websites is necessary, but it is often the least lucky route. Talking to people in your field, showing your work where it can be seen, telling others what you are looking for, all of this widens the space where luck can reach you.

Remember the planes that came back. When you see other people announcing their new jobs, places and contracts, you are seeing the planes that made it home. You are not seeing their forty rejections.

Remember the four boxes. A rejection is an outcome. It could follow a good decision or a bad one. Examine your process, not just your result.

And remember Stockdale. Put your dates on your actions, not on the outcome. *I will send five strong applications this week. I will ask two people for feedback. I will review my approach at the end of the month.* Those are promises you can keep. *I will be accepted by March* is not.

* * *

There is one more thing that a long season of rejection can teach.

In Chapter 12, Sara wrote three words above her desk: security, respect, growth. Now she had to act on them. She began to suspect that at a famous company, a junior analyst might wait years before being trusted with anything serious, while at a smaller firm she might be given real responsibility almost at once. So she widened her aim. She kept applying to large companies, but she also began looking at smaller ones doing serious work in her field.

She messaged one of the two former employees she had met over coffee months earlier, someone she barely knew, and asked whether she knew anyone at such firms. She did. A conversation led to an introduction. The introduction led to an interview.

I will not tell you yet how it turned out, because that belongs to the last chapter. Widening her aim was not a guarantee; for a while it led to more rejections. What it gave her was more roads for the same hope to travel.

The same move is available far beyond job searches. The student refused by one university can ask what that university stood for: a subject, a city, a kind of teacher, a door into a career. Then she can look for other places that offer the same things. The writer turned down by twenty publishers can ask what being

published meant: readers, respect, income, a voice. Some of those can be reached by other doors that are open now.

* * *

Not every closed door is simply a matter of skill and luck, and I want to say that plainly.

Some people face barriers that have nothing to do with their ability: their name, gender, religion, accent, age, disability, nationality or the neighborhood they come from. We saw evidence of this in Chapter 3. If you suspect this is part of what you face, two things can be true at once.

It can be true that you should keep improving your applications, building your skills and widening your search, because those things are in your power.

And it can be true that the barrier is wrong, that it is not your fault and that it is not only your problem to solve. You can seek out organizations with better records. You can find groups that support people in your position. When you are in a position to do so, you can help change the rules for the next person. Effort spent making a system fairer is still effort. It may be the most important kind there is.

* * *

If you are reading this in the middle of a season of closed doors, here is what I would say if I were sitting beside you.

Your pain makes sense. You wanted something good, you worked for it and it did not come. You are allowed to grieve.

But the letter, or the silence, does not get to speak for your whole life. It is one result, from one place, at one time, for reasons you may never know. You are probably stronger than you feel to-

day. There is probably more room around you than you can see from where you stand. And there are certainly doors you have not yet knocked on.

Sharpen the axe. Ask for feedback. Widen your aim. Rest when you need to. Then draw the bow again, not because the next arrow is guaranteed to land, but because the archer who keeps drawing is the only one who ever hits anything at all.

For your quiver

A rejection is a closed door, not a map of the building.

Practice. Write a one-page plan for the next month. Include one specific improvement to your application, portfolio or pitch, one person you will ask for feedback, a manageable number of attempts you will make each week and a date to review your approach. Then write what the door you lost really stood for, and one other door that leads toward the same thing.

Chapter 15: Two yeses

Some goals depend on a committee, a market or the weather. The most painful ones depend on a single human heart.

You can want a business partner who does not want you. You can want a father who will not forgive you. You can want a friendship back after a falling-out the other person has decided to let stand. You can want your family to bless a marriage they will not bless. And you can want, more than you have ever wanted anything, to spend your life with a person who does not want to spend theirs with you.

Of all the stories in this book, this is the one I have been most careful with, because it hurts the most people most deeply.

Let me tell you about Adam. He is a composite, built from many lives.

Adam met Lina at university. They were friends first, then more than friends, slowly and carefully, the way such things often go when families and futures are involved. For four years they talked about the life they would build. They chose, half-joking, the names of their children. They argued about which city they would live in. Adam took a second job in the evenings so he could save, because he wanted to come to her family as a man

who was ready. He believed, with a certainty he could not explain, that she was meant for him.

Then, over the course of a year, something changed. Lina grew quieter. She was slower to answer his messages. When he asked what was wrong, she said nothing was wrong. And one evening, in a café they had gone to since their second year, she told him, gently and with tears in her eyes, that she could not marry him. She did not see her future with him. She was sorry. She had tried to feel what he felt, and she could not.

A year and a half later, Adam saw the wedding photographs.

* * *

I do not know why Lina changed. Neither does Adam, not fully. Perhaps she grew in a different direction. Perhaps her feelings were never as strong as his, and it took her time to admit it, even to herself. Perhaps there were reasons in her life he never saw. I will not invent her motives, because one of the hardest truths of this kind of loss is that the other person's heart is not ours to explain. It is theirs.

And that is where this chapter has to begin.

* * *

In almost every other chapter of this book, the archer has been aiming at a target. Targets do not have opinions. An exam is marked by rules. A job is filled by a decision that preparation can at least influence. Even luck, for all its unpredictability, has no will of its own.

Love is different. Here the target can choose. It has its own aim, its own wind and its own hopes.

This makes love the one goal where your effort must meet another person's freedom. No amount of effort, devotion, sincerity or prayer can make that freedom disappear. You can be the most loving, faithful, hardworking, deserving person in the world, and the person you love can still, freely, choose a different life. Not because you failed. Because they are free.

A future together takes two yeses. One person's yes, however strong, is only half of it.

This is hard to accept, because the old contract from Chapter 1 runs especially deep in love. We absorb it from every film and every song. *If you love someone enough, if you are patient enough, if you prove yourself enough, they will love you back.* It is one of the most beautiful lies we tell, and one of the most dangerous.

It is dangerous for the person who is turned down, because it tells them they were not loving enough, patient enough or good enough. And it can be dangerous for the person who is loved, because someone who believes that devotion earns a right to be loved back may find it very hard to hear the word *no*. Most people can hear it, thankfully. But we all know stories where devotion curdled into pressure, or worse, because someone believed their effort had earned them a person.

Let me say it as plainly as I can. Devotion and effort do not create a right to another person's heart. They never did. The other person's freedom is not an obstacle to love. It is part of what makes love worth having. A love that could be forced would not be love at all.

* * *

Destiny plays a special role in love, and it deserves a close look.

Many of us believe, or want to believe, that there is one person meant for us. The idea is ancient. In Plato's *Symposium*, written in Athens more than two thousand years ago, a group of friends at a dinner party take turns giving speeches about love. The comic playwright Aristophanes tells a myth. Human beings, he says, were once round, double creatures, with four arms, four legs and two faces. They were so strong that the gods feared them, so Zeus split each of them in half. Ever since, every person has wandered the earth searching for their other half. Love is simply the name we give to the longing to be whole again.

It is a beautiful story, and it has shaped how people talk about love for twenty-four centuries. Soulmates. Other halves. *The one. She was meant for me.*

Psychologists have found that how strongly we hold this kind of belief changes how we handle love's difficulties.

In 1998, the psychologist C. Raymond Knee published a study of what he called *implicit theories of relationships*. Some people, he found, hold strong *destiny beliefs*: two people are either meant for each other or they are not, and you can tell fairly early. Others hold strong *growth beliefs*: good relationships are built over time, by working through problems together. Later researchers described these as "soulmate" beliefs and "work-it-out" beliefs.

Knee followed people's dating relationships over time. People with stronger destiny beliefs were more likely to cope with problems by avoiding them, and the survival of their relationships depended more heavily on how good things felt at the very start. People with stronger growth beliefs were more likely to work through problems. And after a relationship ended, people with stronger growth beliefs were less likely to look back and declare it had been wrong from the beginning. They did not rewrite the whole story because of its ending.

These findings matter to anyone who has lost someone they believed was destined for them. Because the belief *she was meant for me* does two things after a loss, and both can hurt.

First, it can turn a painful loss into a total one. If there was only one person meant for me and she has gone, then I have lost not just her but my only chance. I am, in Aristophanes' terms, permanently half.

Second, it can keep a person waiting. *If she is truly meant for me, she will come back.* So he waits. He watches her life from a distance. He turns down other possibilities because they feel like betrayals of what was meant. Months become years. This is the lazy argument from Chapter 8, applied to the heart, and it can cost someone the very years in which a new love might have begun.

You are not half of anything. You were whole before you met them, and you are whole now, even if it does not feel that way tonight.

* * *

I want to be fair to destiny here. For many people, faith that their life is in good hands is exactly what helps them survive a loss like this. *If she was not meant for me, then someone else is, or something else is.* That can be a deeply healthy thought. It looks backward at the loss and makes peace with it, and it looks forward with openness instead of certainty. It does not say *I know who is meant for me.* It says *I trust that my story is not over.*

The difference is the one we met in Chapter 8: destiny used to make peace with the past, versus destiny used to dictate the future. *It was not meant to be* can bring peace. *She is meant to be, so I will wait* can bring years of pain.

* * *

There is another version of this story, and in many parts of the world it is at least as common as Adam's.

Sometimes both people say yes, and someone else says no. Two people love each other completely, both want to marry, and the marriage is blocked by something outside them: families who refuse, differences of community or class or faith, a visa, money, distance, a parent's illness that ties one of them to another city. Here the target was willing. The wind was simply too strong.

This loss has its own particular grief, because it often carries anger as well as sorrow, and sometimes a lifelong *what if*. If this is your story, everything in Chapter 3 about barriers held in place by people applies to you. Some of those barriers can be moved, with time, patience, allies and courage. Some cannot. Knowing which is which is one of the hardest judgments a person is ever asked to make, and you should not have to make it alone.

* * *

Whatever form your loss has taken, remember what we saw in Chapter 11. When you love someone and imagine a life with them, you do not only hope for that life. You begin to live in it. Adam had lived in that future for four years. He had walked through the rooms of the house they would share. He had held children they had named. When Lina said no, he lost a person and a future at the same time, and there was no funeral for either.

His grief was real grief. Yours is too. You do not have to be over it by a certain date, and you do not have to call it a gift.

* * *

So what can someone in Adam's position actually do?

First, honor the other person's choice. This is painful, and it is also a kind of dignity. It means no pressure, no endless pleading, no waiting outside their life for a change of heart. It means accepting that *no* is a complete answer. Many people find, to their surprise, that this is where their own freedom begins. As long as you are fighting their choice, you are tied to it. When you honor it, you can start to walk away.

Second, protect yourself from the planes that came back. Social media lets you watch the life of the person you lost unfold in real time: the engagement, the wedding, the new home. Every picture is a fresh wound. Muting, unfollowing or simply not looking is not petty. It is medicine. You would not reopen a cut every morning to check whether it was healing.

Third, separate the person from the needs. When you are ready, ask what the relationship gave you or promised you. Companionship. Being truly known. Shared values. Laughter. A partner in building a family. A sense of home. Those needs were real, and they did not end when the relationship did. The person cannot be replaced; no person can. But the needs can be met again, in time, in a different way, by different people. That is not betrayal. It is life continuing.

Fourth, let people in. Grief that is hidden grows heavier. Find the friend, the sibling, the counselor, the elder, the stranger in a support group who will let you say it out loud.

And fifth, when the time comes, and only then, let your hope find a new direction. Not a new person to fixate on, and not a rushed replacement, but a reopening to the possibility that love may come again in a shape you have not yet imagined.

* * *

Adam did not do these things quickly. For months he did almost none of them. He checked her profile every night before sleep. He went back to the café alone. He wrote long messages to her and deleted them.

The change, when it came, was small and ordinary. One evening, nearly a year after the café, he picked up his phone at eleven o'clock as usual to look at her page. And this time he put it face down on the table instead. He sat there for a minute, feeling slightly ridiculous. Then he picked it up again and sent a message to an old friend from university he had been avoiding for months: *Are you free on Saturday? Let's get food.*

The friend replied within a minute. They went out that Saturday, and the one after. Nothing dramatic happened. He did not stop loving Lina that night. But he stopped arranging his evenings around her absence, and for the first time in a long while, his hands were free for something else.

It was not a revelation. It was a choice, made once, and then made again the next night, and the night after that. That is usually how the turn begins. Not with a new feeling, but with a new action, repeated until the feeling follows.

We will see where those free hands led him in the last chapter. For now, here is the truest sentence I know about love and effort. You can give someone your whole heart. You cannot give them your will, and you cannot take theirs.

For your quiver

A future together takes two yeses.

Practice. If you are grieving a future that needed someone else's yes, write two lists. In the first, write what you loved about that person or that relationship, as long as it needs to be; this is part of grieving. In the second, write the needs it met or promised to meet. Then choose one small action for tonight that serves one of those needs in a different way: a call, a plan with a friend, an evening spent somewhere new.

Chapter 16: Hold on, or let go

On the twenty-ninth of October 1941, in the darkest year of the Second World War, Winston Churchill visited his old school, Harrow, and gave a short speech to the boys. One part of it has been repeated ever since, on posters, in locker rooms and in a thousand motivational talks: his call never to give in, never, never, never, in anything great or small.

Almost nobody remembers how the sentence ended. Churchill added an exception. Never give in, he said, except to convictions of honor and good sense.

I find that ending wonderful. The most famous speech about never giving up in the English language contains an exception clause. Even Churchill, at a moment when stubbornness was saving his country, knew that persistence and wisdom are not the same thing. There are times when honor and good sense tell you to stop.

The trouble is that nobody tells you exactly when those times are.

* * *

We are surrounded by two sets of advice that flatly contradict each other, and both are delivered with complete confidence.

One set says: never give up. Winners never quit. The moment you want to stop is the moment just before the breakthrough.

The other says: know when to walk away. Don't throw good money after bad. Let go of what isn't working. Doing the same thing and expecting a different result is a kind of madness.

Both are true sometimes. Neither is true always. And most of the people who give this advice decide which version to give based on how things turned out, which, as we saw in Chapter 7, is exactly the wrong way to judge a decision. If you persisted and succeeded, you were a hero who never gave up. If you persisted and failed, you were a fool who could not let go. If you quit and something better came along, you were wise. If you quit and regretted it, you were weak.

So let us think about this more carefully than the posters do.

* * *

The first thing to know is that our minds lean toward continuing, even when continuing makes no sense.

In 1985, the psychologists Hal Arkes and Catherine Blumer ran a neat experiment at a university theater. People buying season tickets for a series of plays were randomly charged one of three prices: full price, or one of two discounts. The tickets were otherwise identical. Then the researchers simply counted how many plays each group attended.

Over the first half of the season, the people who had paid full price went to significantly more plays than those who had paid less.

Why? The money was already spent. It could not be recovered by going, or lost by staying home. The only sensible question was *do I want to see a play tonight?* But the people who had paid

more felt they had more invested, and did not want to "waste" it. They kept going to justify what they had already put in.

Economists call this the *sunk cost fallacy*. Money, time and effort that have already been spent are gone, whatever we do next. Yet we treat them as a debt that obliges us to continue. *I've put five years into this degree. I've sunk so much into this shop. I've given this relationship half my life.* The more we have invested, the harder it becomes to stop, even when stopping is plainly right.

That is why I have learned to distrust persistence when it is the only argument I have for continuing. Before you call persistence a virtue, ask what it is preserving.

* * *

The second thing to know is that letting go of a goal that has truly moved out of reach is not weakness. Often it is health.

The psychologist Carsten Wrosch and his colleagues have spent years studying people who face goals they cannot reach: parents caring for a seriously ill child who must give up career plans, older people who can no longer do work they once loved, young people whose path is suddenly blocked. In studies published in 2003, they found that people who were better able to let go of goals that had become unattainable tended to report better well-being: less distress, fewer signs of depression. People who could not only let go but also *re-engage*, putting their energy into new goals, tended to do better still.

These studies show associations, not strict causes, and they cannot tell any one person when to stop. But they do challenge the idea that refusing to let go is always the most admirable thing

a person can do. Sometimes the strongest move is to open your hand around one goal so that it is free to hold another.

* * *

The third thing to know is that *give up* is not one choice. It is several.

We usually talk as if there are only two options, continue or quit. In real life there are at least four.

You can *continue as you are*, trusting that the same approach will work given more time.

You can *change the method*, keeping the goal but trying a different way to reach it.

You can *pause*, setting the goal aside for a season while you rest, save, heal or deal with other duties, with a plan to return.

And you can *leave the goal*, choosing to put your energy somewhere else.

Many people who feel trapped between "never give up" and "let it go" actually need the second or third option. They do not need to abandon the goal. They need to stop doing what is not working, or to rest.

* * *

How do you know which you need? There is no formula, and I will not pretend there is. But some questions clear the fog.

Is there evidence of progress? Not success, which can take a long time, but progress: getting closer, getting better, getting more specific feedback, more interest, more replies. If there is progress, even slow progress, that is a strong reason to continue. If there has been none for a long time despite real effort, that is a strong reason at least to change the method.

Is the road hard, or is it closed? This is the most important distinction, and it is often blurred. A hard road is one where success is possible but difficult: you need more skill, more attempts, more time, more luck. A closed road is one where success is no longer possible, or no longer possible for you: a clear and final no from another person, an age limit, a rule that will not change, an opportunity that has gone. Hard roads need persistence. Closed roads need the courage to turn around. The cruelest mistakes come from confusing the two: giving up too soon on a hard road, or spending years pushing at a closed one. A hard road and a closed road need two different kinds of courage.

What is it costing? Every goal has a price, in money but also in health, relationships, time and the people who depend on you. Some prices are worth paying. Some are not. Often the people around you can see the cost more clearly than you can. Ask them.

Is the value still alive? Over the years we change. A goal that once expressed who we were may no longer do so, and we keep chasing it out of habit, pride or a promise made long ago. It is worth asking honestly: if I were starting today, knowing what I know now, would I choose this?

Can the value be reached another way? This question opens more doors than any other.

* * *

The psychologist Angela Duckworth, whose research made perseverance famous under the name *grit*, makes a point that people who quote her often miss. Our goals, she suggests, are arranged in a kind of ladder. At the top sits a single, deep, long-lasting purpose: what we care about most. Below it are many smaller goals, which are only means to that end. The top of the ladder is worth

holding stubbornly. The lower rungs should be held more loosely. When one is blocked, it is often wise to swap it for another that serves the same purpose.

Let me give you an example. Maya is a composite.

Maya wanted to be a doctor for as long as she could remember. She applied to medical school three times, and three times she was turned down. Each time she improved her application. Each time the competition was fierce and the places few. After the third rejection she sat with the question we have been asking: is this road hard, or is it closed?

After much grief and much advice, she decided that for her, at least for now, it was closed. Her savings were gone. Her family needed her to work. The odds of a fourth attempt succeeding were real but small.

Then she asked the deeper question. Why did she want to be a doctor? When she was honest, the answer was not the title or the white coat. It was that she wanted to spend her life helping people who were ill and frightened, using science to do it.

Once she named that, she could see that medicine was one road to that place, but not the only one. She trained as a nurse. Years later she specialized in caring for people with cancer. She spends her days doing exactly what she once dreamed of doing: helping frightened, ill people, using science. She is not a doctor, and she still feels a small ache when she sees a white coat. But the reason she wanted the white coat in the first place is alive in her every single day.

The same move appears everywhere once you look for it. The footballer whose knee will not hold up becomes the coach who makes other people's careers. The researcher who cannot find an academic post takes her skills to a hospital, a charity or a government office, and finds her questions are still alive there. The

shopkeeper who closes his shop keeps what he loved about it, the conversations, the trust of regulars, the feeling of running his own day, and builds it into something new. Changing direction can protect the value that first made you begin.

Not every story ends this neatly, and I will not pretend otherwise. Some goals have no substitute that feels anywhere near as good. Some values can only be served in one particular way. Sometimes, when you leave a goal, you lose something nothing will fully replace, and that loss deserves real grief. But far more often than we expect, the thing we were really reaching for can be reached by another road.

* * *

There is one more practice that helps more than any other, because it protects you from making this decision in your worst moment.

Decide in advance.

Before you begin a hard goal, or at a calm moment along the way, write a short review rule. What evidence would tell you to keep going as you are? What evidence would tell you to change the method? What costs will you refuse to pay, whatever happens? And when will you review this: after how many attempts, how much time, how much money?

Then, when the hard moment comes, the night after the third rejection, the month the savings run low, you will not be deciding alone and exhausted. You will be deciding with your calmer, clearer self, who saw this moment coming and left you a note.

It will not make the decision painless. Nothing will. But it will make it yours, and not the decision of your fear, your pride or the money you have already spent.

* * *

Churchill was right. Never give in, never, never, except to honor and good sense.

The archer knows both halves of that sentence. There are seasons to keep drawing at a distant target through rain and wind, because she is getting closer and the target is worth it. And there are seasons to lower the bow, look around the field and see that her arrows would fly truer somewhere else. Neither is weakness. The only weakness is refusing to ask the question.

For your quiver

Quit the road if you must. Keep the reason.

Practice. For one goal you are unsure about, write a review rule. What evidence would tell you to continue? What evidence would tell you to change the method? What costs will you not accept? What deeper value does this goal serve, and what is one other road toward that value? Set a date to read it again, and keep it.

Chapter 17: The archer's discipline

In Japan there is a form of archery called *kyudo*, "the way of the bow." It is practiced in quiet halls with long, asymmetrical bows of bamboo, and for centuries it has been taught as much as a training of the mind as a sport.

Students of kyudo learn each shot as a sequence of eight stages. The archer places her feet. She settles her body. She readies the bow. She raises it. She draws. She holds at full draw. She releases. And then comes the eighth stage, the one I want you to remember.

It is called *zanshin*, which can be translated as "the remaining mind." After the arrow has left the string, the archer does not drop her arms or turn away. She holds her posture, her attention and her composure for a moment longer. The shot is not over when the arrow leaves. It is over when the archer has finished being present to it, whatever the arrow does.

Kyudo teachers like to say that a shot made correctly is already a hit. They mean that when every stage is done well, the arrow tends to find its mark. But the practice does not fix its attention on the target. It fixes its attention on the shooting. The target is where the eyes go last, not first.

This is the closest thing I know to a picture of how to live with effort, luck, destiny and hope at once. Everything before the release is yours to do with your whole heart. The release itself, the moment of hope, is a letting go. And what comes after, *zanshin*, is the part most of us were never taught: how to stay whole and attentive while the arrow flies and lands wherever it lands.

This chapter turns the ideas in this book into a practice, something you can actually do on an ordinary Tuesday when you face something you want and cannot guarantee.

* * *

At the end of the introduction, I gave you the archer's card in five short questions. Here they are again, now with everything the book has added to them.

The bow: What is mine to do?

This is the question of effort. What skill actually decides this? What is the next concrete action? Where can I get honest feedback? What can I do this week that would change the odds, even a little? Is my pace one I can keep? This question deserves your full energy. It is the part of the story that belongs to you.

The wind: What is not mine?

This is the question of luck and circumstance. What forces act on this that I did not choose and cannot control? Other people's decisions, the economy, timing, health, the ground I started from. Naming them does two things. It helps you prepare for them and widen your luck surface where you can. And it stops you blaming yourself for things that were never in your hands.

The page: What story am I telling?

This is the question of destiny and meaning. When I think about this, what story is running in my head? Is it a verdict: *I'm*

not good enough, it was never meant for me, nothing ever works out? Is it a fantasy: *this is destined, it will surely come*? Am I using destiny to make peace with the past, or to excuse myself from the future? Can I add the words *so far*?

The breath: What am I hoping for, and what will I do without knowing how it ends?

This is the question of hope, and it has grown the most since the introduction. Underneath the specific outcome, what is the value I am really reaching for? What is the main obstacle, and what is my if-then plan? What is one action I will take this week even though I cannot know how it ends? What other roads lead toward the same value? Is my hope tied to a date I do not control, and can I move that date onto my own actions instead? And if you pray, this is where prayer belongs: naming what you want, marking the edge of your power and asking for the strength to do your part.

The archer: Who am I, apart from this result?

This is the question that holds the others together. If this arrow misses, what will still be true about me? What will I still care about, still be able to do, still be worth? What part of my life can this result not touch?

The next useful step can be clear even while the final outcome stays uncertain. These questions exist to find it.

* * *

Here is how differently the questions can play out depending on the target.

When Sara asked them about her job search, the answers looked like this.

What is mine to do? A great deal. She could practice interviews with someone who would push back, ask for feedback, widen her search to smaller firms and use the contacts she already had. In her case, the bow was large.

What is not mine? The hiring decisions, the number of positions, the other candidates, internal politics she would never see, the economy. Also, she realized, the summer she could not afford to work for free.

What story am I telling? She noticed a verdict: *I'm not good enough for the places that matter.* She rewrote it: *So far, I haven't got the job I wanted. I reached the final round of a very competitive process, and I don't know why I wasn't chosen.*

What am I hoping for, and what will I do without knowing how it ends? Beneath the famous company, she was hoping for security, respect and growth. Her main obstacle was freezing in final interviews. Her if-then plan: *If I feel myself freezing, I will pause, breathe and tell a short story about a real piece of work.* Her uncertain action for the week: three conversations with people at smaller firms, any of which might lead nowhere.

Who am I, apart from this result? A person who works seriously, learns fast, loves her family and is good at what she does, whether or not one company noticed.

Now look at the same questions for Adam, about Lina.

What is mine to do? Much less. He could not make her love him. He could be honest about his feelings, which he had been. He could respect her decision. He could choose what to do with his evenings, his attention, his phone and his grief.

What is not mine? Almost everything about the outcome. Her heart, her choices, her life. His bow was small, and the target had a will of its own.

What story am I telling? For a long time it was *She was meant for me, so my life is ruined.* Slowly it became: *I loved someone who did not choose me. That is one of the hardest things a person can live through. It does not mean I will never be loved.*

What am I hoping for, and what will I do without knowing how it ends? For months he hoped only for her return, a hope with a single road, and that road was closed. When he was ready, he found what lay beneath it: companionship, being known, building a family with someone who chose him back. His uncertain action was the one we saw in Chapter 15: putting the phone face down, and messaging an old friend about Saturday. He had no idea whether it would help.

Who am I, apart from this result? A man capable of loving faithfully and deeply. That capacity did not leave with her.

Notice how different the two cases are. For Sara, the questions led to a list of actions. For Adam, they led mostly to acceptance and one very small step. Both are right. The point is not always to produce more effort. It is to put effort exactly where it belongs, and nowhere else.

* * *

Some people like something to write on. If you are one of them, here is a single page you can use for any goal or decision. This is the full archer's card.

At the top, write the *goal*: what you are aiming for, in one sentence.

Underneath, the *value*: why it matters, what it is really about.

Then *my next action*, with a date. Just one: the smallest real step.

Then *what I do not control*. Name the wind.

Then *the story I am telling*, and a truer version that begins with *so far*.

Then *the hope*: the value beneath the outcome, the main obstacle, and *if it appears, I will…*

Then *the help I need*, and from whom.

Then *other roads*: at least one other way the same value could be served if this road closes.

Then *if this fails, I will…* This line feels uncomfortable to write. Write it anyway. A plan becomes more honest when it includes what you will do if it fails.

And finally, a *review date*, when you will read the card again and decide whether to continue, change the method, pause or leave.

The card takes ten minutes, and it does two things at once. It makes you more serious about the effort, because the next action has a date. And it makes you less afraid of the outcome, because failure already has a plan and hope already has more than one road.

* * *

If you want to practice these ideas more deliberately, here is a simple month you can try. It is not a program, and it promises no particular result. It is just a way of living with these questions for four weeks, so they become habits rather than ideas.

In the *first week*, choose one goal that matters and fill in an archer's card for it. Spend the week noticing where your energy goes. How much goes to the bow, the things that are yours to do? How much goes to worrying about the wind?

In the *second week*, sharpen one method. Find one source of honest feedback and change one thing in response. Think of the

woodcutter.

In the *third week*, widen your luck surface. Tell three people what you are working on, including at least one acquaintance. Show your work somewhere it can be seen. Keep the luck log from Chapter 4: each evening, a line about what you did, what surprised you, good and bad, and who helped.

In the *fourth week*, review. Read your card and your log. Choose one change to keep, one thing to stop and one uncertainty to carry forward without forcing an answer. Then rewrite the hope line of your card. Notice whether it has more roads than it did a month ago.

Throughout the month, include rest. Include setbacks. Include days when nothing happens. Write down the bad surprises as carefully as the good ones. And do not turn this into another test you can pass or fail. The point of small records is not to score yourself. It is to see your life more accurately than the large, dramatic stories that disappointment tells.

* * *

Let me come back, at the end, to the eighth stage of the kyudo shot: *zanshin*, the remaining mind.

Most of us have been taught a lot about the first seven stages, even if we never called them that. We have been taught to prepare, to work, to aim and to try. Some of us have been taught to pray. Almost none of us were taught what to do in the moment after the release, when the arrow is gone and we are waiting, or when it has landed somewhere we did not want.

Zanshin says: stay. Do not collapse. Do not turn away in shame or rush to the next arrow in a panic. Hold your form.

Watch with clear eyes where the arrow went. Feel whatever you feel. And remain yourself, an archer, whatever the target says.

After the arrow leaves, the archer remains.

Then, when you are ready, lower the bow, walk back to the line and draw again.

For your quiver

After the arrow leaves, the archer remains.

Practice. Fill in one full archer's card this week for something you care about: the goal, the value, your next dated action, what you do not control, the story you are telling and a truer *so far* version, your hope with its obstacle and if-then plan, the help you need, other roads, what you will do if it fails and a review date. Keep it where you will see it every day.

Chapter 18: A life larger than the target

A palliative care nurse in Australia named Bronnie Ware spent several years looking after people in the last weeks of their lives. She sat with them, listened to them and eventually wrote down what they told her about their regrets, first in a blog post and then in a book, *The Top Five Regrets of the Dying*.

Two of the regrets she heard most often have stayed with me through the writing of this book, because at first they seem to pull in opposite directions.

The first was a wish to have had the courage to live a life true to oneself, rather than the life others expected. People regretted the dreams they had never even tried for: the roads not taken because they were afraid, because someone disapproved, because the odds looked too long.

The second was a wish not to have worked so hard. People regretted years spent chasing results at the expense of everything else: family, friends, health, joy. Ware wrote that she heard this from every male patient she nursed.

So the dying regretted not trying hard enough for the things that mattered. And they regretted trying too hard for things that, in the end, mattered less than they had thought.

At first this sounds like a contradiction. I have come to believe it is the whole answer.

* * *

Research on regret points the same way. In the 1990s, the psychologists Thomas Gilovich and Victoria Medvec studied what people regret over different spans of time. In the short term, they found, people tend to regret their actions more: the thing they said, the risk that did not pay off, the decision that went badly. But over the long term, the pattern tends to reverse. Looking back across years and decades, people more often regret what they did *not* do: the chance not taken, the person not approached, the dream never attempted.

Later researchers have argued about how strong and universal this pattern is, as they should. But its core has held up well enough to deserve a place in any honest answer to the question this book began with: why try at all, if trying guarantees nothing?

One answer is this. The arrow you release may miss, and you will grieve it and recover. The arrow you never release does not miss. It simply follows you, for the rest of your life, as a question.

* * *

The second regret warns us about the opposite danger. We can try for one thing so completely that we starve everything else. We can make a single target the measure of our whole life, so that when we hit it we look around and find the rest of our life has gone silent, and when we miss it there is nothing left standing.

Viktor Frankl believed that human beings find meaning in three broad ways. We find it in what we create or do: our work,

our deeds, what we give the world. We find it in what we experience and whom we love: beauty, truth, another human being. And we find it in the stance we take toward suffering we cannot avoid.

Only the first of these depends much on outcomes, and even there, much of the meaning lives in the doing rather than the result. Love does not depend on winning. The stance we take toward suffering does not depend on succeeding. A life that rests on all three is like a table with three legs. If one leg is shortened by a lost job or a failed dream, the table tips, but it does not fall.

A life that rests on one outcome is a table with one leg.

Give the goal your best. Do not give it your worth.

* * *

I promised to tell you how the stories ended. They have not really ended, of course; nobody's story ends in the last chapter of someone else's book. But here is where I last left them.

Sara took the job at the smaller firm. It paid a little less than the famous company would have. Within six months she was handling clients on her own. Within two years she was leading a small team, something she might have waited five or six years to do in the glass building. She is good at her work and respected for it, and she has been able to help her family the way she hoped.

Sometimes she still passes the glass building on the bus. When she does, there is a small sting first, and then, usually, something else: a surprised kind of gratitude for the road she ended up on. She does not know whether the other road would have been better. It might have been. She has stopped needing to know. *Who knows*, said the old man at the frontier, and she has learned to say it too.

Daniel, who got the job she wanted, did well there. For the first few months it felt like the best thing that had ever happened to him. By the end of the first year it felt like a job: some days wonderful, some days dull, with a manager who was not always fair. In his second year he was passed over for a promotion he had worked hard for and believed he deserved. He did not know why. He went home that night, sat in his kitchen and read the email twice, as if the words might rearrange themselves.

I tell you this not because I want Daniel to suffer, but because I want you to see that winning did not excuse him from being human. The arrow that hits does not end the shooting. There is always another target, another wind, another morning. The winners and losers of any one contest turn out to be the same people, at different moments in the same long life.

Omar found work after eight months, a reasonable job at a reasonable company. He still does not know whether declining that first offer was right. His decision journal tells him his reasoning was careful and his concerns were real. The result tells him it cost him eight hard months. He has made a kind of peace with holding both. Some questions do not get answered. They get carried, and over time they grow lighter.

Nadia, the student choosing between her notes and her phone, chose the notes most evenings and her phone on some. She passed two of her three papers and failed the third by a narrow margin. She retook it the next term, after changing how she studied, and passed. She now tells younger students that the failed paper taught her more than the two she passed, and she is careful to add that she would still rather have passed it the first time.

Maya is still a nurse. She still feels a small ache when she sees a doctor’s white coat. And she still goes to work every day to do

exactly what she wanted to do with her life.

And Adam.

It has been three years since the café. Adam has not married. Some evenings, especially around the date he once planned to propose, he still thinks of Lina, and it still hurts. He has not looked at her page since the night he put the phone face down. The Saturday dinners with his old friend became a habit, and the habit became a circle of friends. He moved to a new city for work and found, to his surprise, that he loves training the young people who join his team. Recently, cautiously, he has begun getting to know someone. He does not know where it will lead. He is not calling it destiny. He is calling it a beginning.

His life is no longer arranged around an absence. That, I think, is what recovery from a loss like his really looks like. Not forgetting. Not replacing. Just a life that has grown large enough to hold the loss inside it, instead of a loss so large that it holds the life.

* * *

These are invented people, and I have given them gentle endings, gentler perhaps than real life always gives. But I have made the endings different from one another, because real endings are. One reached a goal by changing it. One reached a goal and found it was not the end of wanting. One is still carrying a question. One failed, changed her method and passed. One is living a different version of the same dream. One is still grieving and still living.

What they share is not an outcome. It is something more important. Each of them, in their own way, refused to let a single result become the title of their life. And each of them, at some

point, took a breath and acted without knowing how it would end. That is what hope looks like from the outside. It rarely looks like confidence. It usually looks like someone picking up the bow again with shaking hands.

* * *

So let me bring the four words back to the table one last time, the four words that started all of this.

Hard work is real. It is the bow, the part that belongs to you. It changes the odds, builds skill, creates places for luck to land and gives you something to say yes with when opportunity arrives. It deserves your full effort, aimed well and paced so you can sustain it.

Luck is real. It is the wind, blowing since the day you were born and blowing still. It shapes the ground you start from and the openings that appear. It can be noticed, invited and prepared for, never commanded. It explains much of what success stories leave out, and much of why sincere people lose.

Destiny, whatever it is, is the page. If it is written, your effort is written on it too, part of the ink and not outside it. Whether or not it is written, you can only read it backward. It is a beautiful word for making peace with the past and a dangerous word for excusing yourself from the future.

Hope is the breath before the release, and it turns out to be the force that holds the other three together. Without it, nobody would draw a bow whose arrow they cannot steer. At its weakest, hope is a fantasy with a date attached. At its strongest, it is a direction with many roads: the decision to act toward something that matters, in a world that promises nothing, and to keep find-

ing another way when one closes. For many people, it is also prayer. For everyone, it is the reason to try again.

They were never really at war. They only seemed to be, because each of us was trying to live on one of them alone.

* * *

The life I wish for you after all this is not a life in which every arrow hits. No such life exists, and I would be lying if I promised it.

It is a life in which you draw the bow with your whole heart, for things that are worth it. In which you know the wind when you feel it, and do not take it personally. In which you tell your story honestly, including the parts you did not choose. In which you hope in a way that can survive a missed target, with more than one road and no appointment with the universe. And in which, when an arrow misses, as some always will, you remain: whole, attentive, still yourself, still an archer.

A life can be unfinished in its ambitions and still be full in its meaning.

For your quiver

Give the goal your best. Do not give it your worth.

Practice. Write three short paragraphs. In the first, write what you will pursue next and why it matters to you. In the second, write how you will treat yourself and the people around you while you pursue it. In the third, write what will still be worth caring about in your life if this attempt fails. Keep the third paragraph somewhere safe. You may need to read it one day.

Epilogue: Why try?

We began with a question, and I promised you a careful answer. Here it is, as plainly as I can give it.

If hard work cannot guarantee the result, if luck can undo the best preparation, if destiny may already be written and if prayers are sometimes answered with a no, then why try at all?

Try, because effort is the one vote you always get to cast, even in contests you cannot control.

Try, because opportunity has to find you somewhere, and it almost never finds people who are standing still.

Try, because if anything is written, your trying is written too. And if nothing is written, your trying is how anything gets written at all.

Try, because a missed arrow ends in grief, and grief, given time and company, eases. An arrow never released ends in a question, and questions do not ease. They wait.

Try, because of what the trying makes of you: the skill, the nerve, the friends met on the way, the larger room you live in afterward, the self you discover only when you want something badly enough to go after it.

Try, because hope without action is only a wish, and action without hope is only a habit. Together they are the closest thing a

human being has to a hand on the future.

And try, finally, because the outcome was never yours to own. The aim always was.

* * *

At the start of this book, I mentioned a song whose chorus admits that all the trying, all the distance covered, came to nothing in the end. I understand why people sing it. I have felt it. On the night the email arrives, or the conversation in the café ends, or the letter from the embassy is opened, it can feel like the truest thing anyone has ever said.

I do not believe it anymore.

It mattered. Not because it guaranteed anything, but because it was real. You prepared, and the preparation became part of you. You loved, and the love was not wasted because it was not returned. You hoped, and the hope carried you through days that would otherwise have stopped you. Perhaps you prayed, and the prayer steadied your hands. None of it bought the result. All of it was yours.

In the end, it does matter. Not because of where the arrow landed, but because of who drew the bow.

* * *

I want to leave you with a picture.

It is early morning in a wide field. The grass is wet. Far down the field there is a target, small at this distance, and you are not sure you can reach it. You have missed it before. Some of your arrows are still lying in the grass where they fell.

You walk to the line. You set your feet. You feel the wind on your face, and you know you cannot stop it; you can only learn to

read it. You do not know what is written about this arrow, and you will not know until it lands. You take a breath, and whether you send it upward or simply let it go into the cold air, it steadies you. That breath is hope. It is not certainty. It was never meant to be.

Then you draw. Not because the arrow is guaranteed to hit. Because you are an archer, and this is what archers do.

The wind is blowing. The page is open. The target is far away.

Breathe. Draw.

The lines worth keeping

Fifteen arrows from this book, for the days you need them.

No farmer has ever believed that plowing guarantees rain. Every farmer plows.

Exhaustion is a cost, not a contribution.

Your starting point was luck. Your direction is not only luck.

Work does not summon luck. It builds a place for luck to land.

Before you copy a winner, count the people who did the same thing and lost.

The old man did not say it was good. He said it was not finished.

Judge the decision by what you knew, not by what the dice did.

A caused action can still be a cause.

There is no funeral for a future that never arrived. Hold one anyway.

Give your hope more than one road to travel.

Hope that sets a date with the universe will one day be stood up.

A future together takes two yeses.

Quit the road if you must. Keep the reason.

After the arrow leaves, the archer remains.

Give the goal your best. Do not give it your worth.

Notes and sources

The research and history in this book come from the sources below. Where a study is described, I have tried to report its setting and its limits along with its findings. Where the book reports what someone said or wrote, it does so in paraphrase. Sara, Daniel, Omar, Nadia, Maya, Adam and Lina are composites: their names are invented and their stories are built from many lives.

Introduction

The song is Linkin Park, "In the End," from the album *Hybrid Theory* (Warner Bros., 2000). Its chorus is described, not quoted.

The image of the archer comes from Cicero, *De Finibus Bonorum et Malorum* (*On Ends*), Book III, section 22, where the Stoic speaker compares the wise person to someone aiming at a mark: the aim is to be pursued with everything, while the hit itself is something to be preferred, not something on which one's good depends.

Chapter 1: The contract nobody signed

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Melvin J. Lerner, *The Belief in a Just World: A Fundamental Delusion* (New York: Plenum, 1980).

Chapter 2: Sweat is not a strategy

The woodcutters' story is a folk tale told in many versions. The saying about sharpening the axe is widely credited to Abraham Lincoln, but quotation researchers have found no evidence that he said it.

K. Anders Ericsson, Ralf Th. Krampe and Clemens Tesch-Römer, "The role of deliberate practice in the acquisition of expert performance," *Psychological Review* 100, no. 3 (1993): 363–406. Ericsson's objections to the "ten thousand hour rule" are set out in K. Anders Ericsson and Robert Pool, *Peak: Secrets from the New Science of Expertise* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin Harcourt, 2016).

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Chapter 3: The ground under the ladder

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Robert K. Merton, "The Matthew effect in science," *Science* 159, no. 3810 (1968): 56–63; and "The Matthew effect in science, II: Cumulative advantage and the symbolism of intellectual property," *Isis* 79, no. 4 (1988): 606–623.

Alex Bell, Raj Chetty, Xavier Jaravel, Neviana Petkova and John Van Reenen, "Who becomes an inventor in America? The importance of exposure to innovation,"

Quarterly Journal of Economics 134, no. 2 (2019): 647–713.

Warren Buffett has used the phrase "ovarian lottery" in many talks and interviews over several decades, including Berkshire Hathaway shareholder meetings and talks to students. See also Alice Schroeder, *The Snowball: Warren Buffett and the Business of Life* (New York: Bantam, 2008).

Robert H. Frank, *Success and Luck: Good Fortune and the Myth of Meritocracy* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2016).

Chapter 4: Why luck loves the hardworking

On the history of the saying that hard work brings luck, see the Thomas Jefferson Encyclopedia at Monticello, which lists the Jefferson attribution as spurious, and the research published by Quote Investigator on its earlier variants.

Alexander Fleming, "On the antibacterial action of cultures of a penicillium, with special reference to their use in the isolation of B. influenzae," *British Journal of Experimental Pathology* 10, no. 3 (1929): 226–236.

Louis Pasteur made his remark about chance and the prepared mind in his inaugural lecture at the new Faculty of Sciences in Lille, 7 December 1854.

Richard Wiseman, "The luck factor," *Skeptical Inquirer* 27, no. 3 (May/June 2003), and Richard Wiseman, *The Luck Factor* (2003). The newspaper experiment is described in the *Skeptical Inquirer* article.

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Chapter 5: The planes that came back

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Robert H. Frank's simulations are described in *Success and Luck* (see Chapter 3). For a related model, see Alessandro Pluchino, Alessio Emanuele Biondo and Andrea Rapisarda, "Talent versus luck: The role of randomness in success and failure," *Advances in Complex Systems* 21, nos. 3–4 (2018): 1850014.

Chapter 6: The old man at the frontier

The story of the old man at the frontier (*Sai Weng*) is in the *Huainanzi*, chapter 18, compiled at the court of Liu An, King of Huainan, in the second century BCE. For an English translation, see John S. Major, Sarah A. Queen, Andrew Seth Meyer and Harold D. Roth, trans., *The Huainanzi* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2010).

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Chapter 7: A good decision can lose

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Chapter 8: If the future is fixed, why try?

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Chapter 9: Reading the page backward

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Chapter 10: The room you have to act

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Chapter 11: When the future you imagined disappears

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Chapter 12: The thing with feathers

Hesiod, *Works and Days*, the story of Pandora. The "box" comes from Erasmus's sixteenth-century Latin rendering of the Greek *pithos*, a storage jar.

Friedrich Nietzsche, *Human, All Too Human* (1878), section 71.

Emily Dickinson, the poem beginning "'Hope' is the thing with feathers," first published in 1891, after her death. The poem is described, not quoted.

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Václav Havel, *Disturbing the Peace: A Conversation with Karel Hvížďala*, translated by Paul Wilson (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1990).

Chapter 13: The optimists who did not come home

Jim Collins, *Good to Great: Why Some Companies Make the Leap… and Others Don't* (New York: HarperBusiness, 2001), chapter 4, which recounts Collins's conversation with James Stockdale and names the Stockdale Paradox. See also Jim and Sybil Stockdale, *In Love and War* (New York: Harper & Row, 1984).

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Chapter 14: The door that did not open

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Chapter 15: Two yeses

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C. Raymond Knee, "Implicit theories of relationships: Assessment and prediction of romantic relationship initiation, coping, and longevity," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 74, no. 2 (1998): 360–370. The terms "soulmate" and "work-it-out" beliefs come from Renae Franiuk, Dov Cohen and Eva M. Pomerantz, "Implicit theories of relationships: Implications for relationship satisfaction and longevity," *Personal Relationships* 9, no. 4 (2002): 345–367.

Chapter 16: Hold on, or let go

Winston Churchill, speech at Harrow School, 29 October 1941.

Hal R. Arkes and Catherine Blumer, "The psychology of sunk cost," *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes* 35, no. 1 (1985): 124–140.

Carsten Wrosch, Michael F. Scheier, Gregory E. Miller, Richard Schulz and Charles S. Carver, "Adaptive self-regulation of unattainable goals: Goal disengagement, goal reengagement, and subjective well-being," *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin* 29, no. 12 (2003): 1494–1508.

Angela Duckworth, *Grit: The Power of Passion and Perseverance* (New York: Scribner, 2016), on the hierarchy of goals.

Chapter 17: The archer's discipline

The eight stages of the shot (*shaho hassetsu*) and the teaching that a correct shot is already a hit (*seisha hitchu*) are part of standard kyudo instruction in Japan.

Chapter 18: A life larger than the target

Bronnie Ware, *The Top Five Regrets of the Dying* (2011; Carlsbad, CA: Hay House, 2012).

Thomas Gilovich and Victoria Husted Medvec, "The experience of regret: What, when, and why," *Psychological Review* 102, no. 2 (1995): 379–395. For the debate that followed, see Thomas Gilovich, Victoria Husted Medvec and Daniel Kahneman, "Varieties of regret: A debate and partial resolution," *Psychological Review* 105, no. 3 (1998): 602–605.

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Further reading

Robert H. Frank, *Success and Luck* (2016), on fortune and merit. Oliver Burkeman, *Four Thousand Weeks: Time Management for Mortals* (2021), on finitude and the wish to control life. Christian Busch, *The Serendipity Mindset* (2020), on noticing and using unexpected openings. Gabriele Oettingen, *Rethinking Positive Thinking* (2014), on the difference between fantasy and hope. Robert Sapolsky, *Determined* (2023), for the strongest modern case against free will.

A small request

If this book helped you, even a little, there is one thing you could do that would help it reach someone else who needs it. Leave an honest review wherever you bought it, or pass it to a friend who is standing in their own field right now, looking at the place where their arrow should have landed.

Most people who are struggling with these questions do not go looking for a book about them. They find one because somebody they trust put it in their hands.

About the author

Muhammad Waqas has spent years thinking about four ideas that people build their lives on, hard work, luck, destiny and hope, and about why they so often seem to contradict each other. He noticed, many times, that when he worked hard his luck seemed to improve. He also watched hardworking, hopeful people lose the things they wanted most. *The Archer and the Wind* is his attempt to make sense of both.